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India records highest quarterly FDI in 15 years
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INSIDE



Meta agrees to \$17-bn settlement in addiction case

OAKLAND
Meta has agreed to pay \$17 billion and add child-safety measures to its Facebook and Instagram platforms to end a landmark trial over teen social media addiction and settle claims filed by 47 U.S. states. The agreement is worth \$353 million in the state of Virginia alone. » **PAGE 14**

Amend Aadhaar Act to help 'trace, deport illegals'

MUMBAI
The Bombay High Court has directed the Centre and the Unique Identification Authority of India to consider amending the Aadhaar (Targeted Delivery of Financial and Other Subsidies, Benefits and Services) Act, 2016, to promptly trace and deport of foreign nationals living illegally in India. » **PAGE 4**

Maharashtra PSC halts recruitment over paper leak

MUMBAI
The Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC) cancelled the recruitment process for Drug Inspector, Group-B posts in the Food and Drug Administration Department, on Wednesday after an inquiry by the Mumbai Police found that the question paper of the screening test held on March 22 had been leaked. » **PAGE 4**

West Asia tension increases wait for LPG connections

NEW DELHI
People across the country continue to wait for new LPG connections as supplies remain uncertain due to the West Asia conflict. Distributors in New Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata, Bengaluru, and Chennai said they have not issued any new connections for the 14.2 kg cylinders for domestic use since mid-March. » **PAGE 6**

157 killed in Nepal flash flood, hundreds of people missing

Around 133 Indians reported missing after a flooded Bhotekoshi River swamped villages bordering Tibet

A rock-and-ice landslide on the China border caused a debris-laden flood, officials say citing satellite images

Sanjeev Satgainya
KATHMANDU

At least 157 people were killed and more than 400 people, 133 Indians among them, were missing or out of contact after a massive flash flood in Nepal's Bhotekoshi River swept through villages in Rasuwa, a district bordering China's Tibet region, on Wednesday morning, authorities said.

According to Nepal's Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers, 391 foreign nationals and 93 Nepali citizens were out of contact. "Several security personnel, government officials and employees of hydropower projects are also out of contact," the government said. "The disaster has damaged 19 motorable bridges and 40 kilometres of road."

The Nepal Police said that 157 bodies had been recovered. As authorities stepped up rescue operations, officials said the death toll could rise.



Flood fury: A screengrab shows water flowing across a residential area and damaging a bridge near the Nepal-Tibet border. PTI

PM Modi promises all possible assistance to tragedy-hit Nepal

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to Nepal's Prime Minister Balendra

Shah and offered "all possible assistance" to deal with the flash flood. "Our teams are coordinating closely on rescue and relief efforts,"

said Mr. Modi on X. An Indian Air Force aircraft with 10 tonnes of relief materials and medical supplies took off to Nepal from the Hindon

airbase. Additional aircraft have been earmarked for rescue and evacuation.

FULL REPORT ON
» **PAGE 4**

ing affected people is our first priority," he said.

Earlier, Foreign Minister Shishir Khanal told Parliament that preliminary information suggested an earthquake around 8.37 a.m. triggered an ice avalanche, which was followed by the flood around 8.40 a.m. "The information needed further verification," he said.

Officials at the Flood Forecasting Division had separately said they received information that a landslide may have blocked a river in Tibet before water burst through. In an update at 1.35 p.m., the division said, citing information from the Chinese side, that the blocked river had yet to fully open.

The Bhotekoshi River,

which originates in Tibet, flows into Nepal's Trishuli River and eventually enters India as the Gandak River.

Mr. Khanal told Parliament that the flood had caused extensive damage in Timure and Syafrubesi in Rasuwa, and in Betravati, Trishuli, Battar and Devighat in neighbouring Nuwakot. Roads, bridges, hydropower and communications infrastructure were among those damaged.

According to Nepali authorities, there had been no rain in the region before the flood hit, while rainfall was recorded on the Tibetan side. In July last year, flash floods in the same Bhotekoshi River, which also occurred without rain, killed nine people and

washed away the Miteri Pul (Friendship Bridge) linking Nepal and China.

A Cabinet meeting in the afternoon directed authorities to urgently restore roads, electricity and telecommunications in the affected areas and to mobilise resources to rebuild damaged public infrastructure. It also decided to declare the affected local governments in Rasuwa, Nuwakot, and Dhading as disaster-crisis areas for three months.

Experts concerned
The recurrence of extreme floods has raised concerns among experts about disaster preparedness, infrastructure planning and risk mitigation.

"I think we should ana-

lyse today's incident in a larger frame; it's not a standalone event. The Melamchi, Roshi, and Seti floods, etc, show that these kinds of extreme events are occurring across the Himalayas and are becoming more frequent," said Ramesh Bhushal, a journalist who has extensively covered climate change and its impact. "While such disasters may happen regardless of our understanding, the high casualties are the result of ignorance."

A construction spree along rivers in Nepal's northern regions has remained a concern for environmentalists and climate experts.

WESTERN DISTURBANCE
» **PAGE 4**

Why was Acting CJ of Rajasthan HC not shifted, judge asks CJI

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

In three letters to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, Supreme Court judge Justice Sandeep Mehta this month asked why his "fervent appeals" for the transfer of Rajasthan High Court Acting Chief Justice (ACJ) Sanjeev Prakash Sharma have been "ignored" despite there being "clear evidence" of "favouritism".

Justice Mehta, in the letters, had accused Justice Sharma of maladministration and malpractices on both the judicial and administrative side of the High Court. He had written that he had information on Justice Sharma humiliating judicial officers to satisfy a "personal vendetta" and designating a "large number of favoured advocates as seniors".

Using terms such as "rampant nepotism and favouritism", Justice Mehta wrote that anguished judges of the High Court have said they were "frequently threatened" with retributive action.

CJI's response

In a press statement on August 26, CJI Kant emphasised that he has already taken note of the concerns raised in the letters. He stressed that "allegations against a sitting judge must be dealt with strictly through the established institutional mechanism".

The CJI maintained that the judge concerned must be given a fair opportunity to place his response before any conclusion was reached.

"Any decision regarding the continuation, transfer or other administrative action concerning the acting Chief Justice would be taken by the competent institutional authority after due consideration of the material," the statement read.

In his first letter on August 2, 2026, Justice Mehta had written to the CJI about the "grim and disturbing scenario" in his parent High Court in Rajasthan.

He said the ACJ of the High Court, who is due to retire on September 26, displayed a total lack of leadership qualities and exhibited conduct unbecoming of a leader of the institution on more than one occasion. He reminded the CJI that he had been making repeated requests for the appointment of a regular Chief Justice to the High Court since the beginning of 2026.

"However, till date, the request to have a Chief Justice from another State in my parent High Court has met with no positive response," he wrote.

He said there was maladministration and malpractices on both the judicial and administrative side of the High Court.

Cases were suddenly withdrawn and moved to the Bench of the Acting Chief Justice (ACJ) without any justifiable cause, Jus-

It is indeed ironical that on one hand, the CJI is flagging corrupt practices by judges in the eve of their careers, and here we have an ACJ indulging in these very activities

JUSTICE SANDEEP MEHTA
SC judge

Justice Mehta alleged. He said he was initially asked by the CJI to provide a list of these cases in writing, but was immediately thereafter assured that there was no need to place anything in writing and that suitable action would be taken.

'Personal vendetta'

The next letter, on August 10, noted that the CJI had asked Justice Sharma to respond to the shifting of cases, but said no specific information was further available on the reply or facts of these cases.

Justice Mehta wrote that he had "positive information" that Justice Sharma called and humiliated judicial officers in Rajasthan to satisfy a "personal vendetta". A full court meeting was organised to designate a "large number of favoured advocates as seniors", that too, on a working day, he accused. He wrote that he had been "informed" of the preparation of a "fanciful plan" for a multi-storied tower with almost 100 rooms to function as a guest house for the High Court, calling it a "sheer waste of public money".

Justice Mehta also wrote that anguished judges of the High Court have said they were "frequently threatened" with retributive action, including transfer, by the ACJ, who claimed "closeness" with the CJI.

He noted that the CJI's Bench had recently observed the growing trend of judges passing orders for extraneous considerations in the autumn days of their careers.

"It is indeed ironical that on one hand, the Chief Justice of India is flagging corrupt practices by judges in the eve [towards the end] of their careers, and here we have an ACJ indulging in these very activities with impunity," one of the letters said.

In his last letter on August 17, Justice Mehta uses terms like "rampant nepotism and favouritism" to describe the ACJ's actions.

'Why such a long rope'

He said it was "beyond comprehension" why "such a long rope" was given to a judge whose request for repatriation to the Rajasthan High Court was not accepted by the Supreme Court Collegium in March 2023.

Justice Sharma was appointed Acting Chief Justice of Rajasthan in September last year.

U.S. pauses immigrant visa appointments worldwide

Reuters
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump's administration has issued a pause on immigrant visa appointments for applicants around the world amid a crackdown on immigration.

A State Department spokesperson said on Tuesday that it launched a global training initiative at all U.S. embassies and consulates worldwide and that appointments for visa services will be adjusted to accommodate the training.

Mr. Trump has pursued an aggressive deportation drive and immigration crackdown that includes revocations of visas and green cards and rejection of applications over a range of reasons like political opinions and pro-Palestinian protests against U.S. ally Israel's assault on Gaza.

He says the crackdown aims to improve domestic security. The crackdown has faced some legal setbacks. A U.S. judge on Friday struck down a Trump administration policy suspending the issuance of immigrant visas to applicants from 75 countries, saying that the policy exceeded Secretary of State Marco Rubio's statutory authority.



U.S. President Donald Trump

day struck down a Trump administration policy suspending the issuance of immigrant visas to applicants from 75 countries, saying that the policy exceeded Secretary of State Marco Rubio's statutory authority.

The State Department did not specify details on the training and its timeline, beyond saying the training aimed to help consular officers screen out applicants deemed likely to become dependent on U.S. public benefits and to ensure evaluation of visa applicants "comprehensively and consistently".

The pause on visa ap-

pointments was reported earlier by the *Financial Times*, which said immigrant visa applicants with scheduled interviews at U.S. embassies and consulates have received emails that their appointments were being rescheduled and that they would receive future notice of a new date.

Mr. Trump's immigration crackdown has been widely condemned by human rights groups as being discriminatory and in violation of free speech and

due process rights. Rights groups also say the crackdown has created an unsafe environment in the U.S., especially for ethnic minorities who have raised concerns about racial profiling.

While Mr. Trump campaigned in 2024 on a platform of stopping illegal immigration, his administration has also made legal immigration more difficult—for example, by imposing new and expensive fees for applicants of certain work visas.

INBRIEF



Amritpal wants to take Punjab back to 1980s, alleges Sukhbir

Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) president Sukhbir Singh Badal on Wednesday attacked jailed Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh, alleging that he wanted to take Punjab back to the 1980s when no one was safe. Mr. Badal was addressing the second phase of his party's 'Punjab Bachao' (Save Punjab) campaign in Malout. It was his first public address after he was attacked in Nanded in Maharashtra. On August 13, he sustained injuries to his right hand in a 'kirpan' (ceremonial dagger) attack by a member of the Nihang order inside a gurdwara on the outskirts of the Maharashtra town. The attacker was later arrested. PTI

Black-and-yellow taxis, autos to cost more in Mumbai

Commuting by CNG-run black-and-yellow cabs and auto rickshaws will be costlier for people in Mumbai from September 1 with the transport authority on Wednesday revising its fares, officials said. The Mumbai Metropolitan Region Transport Authority has approved a fare hike of ₹2 for black-and-yellow taxis and ₹1 for auto-rickshaws plying in the metropolitan region, an official of the Regional Transport Office said. After the revision, passengers will have to pay ₹33 instead of the existing ₹31 for the first 1.5 km in a taxi, while the minimum fare for an auto-rickshaw will increase to ₹27 from ₹26, he said. PTI

Meghalaya House passes resolution against mining and processing of uranium

Local communities in the State have been resisting the proposed exploration of the radioactive mineral in Domiasiat, Lostoin, Mawthabab, and Wakhaji areas of South West Khasi Hills district

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Meghalaya Assembly on Wednesday adopted a resolution opposing uranium mining and the establishment of any uranium ore-processing facility in the State.

Chief Minister Conrad K. Sangma moved the resolution in the 60-member House and said the government was on the same page as communities living in the uranium-bearing areas of the West Khasi Hills district.

The resolution referred to the Supreme Court's 2019 order in the State of Meghalaya versus the All Dimas Students' Union, which recognised the rights of private and community landowners over both the surface and the minerals beneath their land.

"Meghalaya is governed by a distinctive constitutional and customary framework under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitu-



A man checking for uranium deposits on the banks of the Wah Blei river in West Khasi Hills district of Meghalaya. FILE PHOTO

tion, which protects community, clan, and individual ownership of land and resources," Mr. Sangma said.

The Assembly resolution was intended to record Meghalaya's opposition to uranium extraction and processing, the CM said. "We will communicate the decision of the House to the Centre," he added.

The resolution, ahead of the Anti-Uranium Day observed in Meghalaya on October 28, seeks to provide a legislative shield to a de-

cades-old public movement against the exploration of the radioactive mineral.

Anti-Uranium Day marks the death anniversary of Spility Lyngdoh Langrin, a matriarch who led the protest against uranium exploration in the Domiasiat, Lostoin, Mawthabab, and Wakhaji areas in the 1990s. She died at 95 in 2020.

She became a household name when she rejected a lucrative government offer to buy her land after

the Atomic Minerals Directorate undertook exploratory drilling for uranium deposits in 1993. The protests she spearheaded forced the directorate to suspend operations a couple of years later.

Langrin led the second phase of the agitation in 2009 after the Meghalaya government granted permission to the Uranium Corporation of India Limited to undertake exploratory activities on 422 hectares in the district.

Relentless protests

Relentless protests by locals, educated about the effects of uranium mining in Jharkhand's Jaduguda, made the government revoke the permission in August 2016.

Meghalaya has one of the country's largest reserves of high-grade uranium in South West Khasi Hills. The estimated 9.22 million tonnes of uranium deposits in the State are 16% of the country's total reserves.

Cong. to hold march against Kaziranga ESZ reduction plan

Press Trust of India
GUWAHATI

The Opposition Congress in Assam on Wednesday said it will organise a Statewide 'padayatra' on August 29 to protest the proposed reduction of the Eco-Sensitive Zone (ESZ) around Kaziranga National Park. The party said the move posed a serious threat to wildlife, biodiversity and the fragile ecosystem of the UNESCO World Heritage Site.

In a circular, State Congress general secretary (organisation) Ramanna Baruah asked all district committee presidents to organise the padayatra and directed leaders and workers to participate actively and mobilise public opinion against the proposed reduction.

The controversy stems from the Assam government's plan to send a proposal to the Centre, seeking a reduction in the buffer area around Kaziranga from the default 10 km to between 1 km and 3 km.

Commercial activities within an ESZ, or buffer zone around a protected forest, are either prohibited, regulated or permitted under specified norms depending on the nature of



Environmentalists have warned that a narrower buffer zone could increase human-animal conflict. FILE PHOTO

the activity.

Opposition parties and environmental activists have alleged that the proposed reduction is aimed at facilitating mining and tourism activities in and around the forest area and the Karbi Anglong hills, which also serve as an elephant corridor.

CM defends proposal

Environmentalists have warned that a narrower buffer zone could increase human-animal conflict.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, however, has strongly defended the proposal, saying the reduction is intended to protect villagers living within the ESZ and safeguard their livelihoods.

Uttarakhand BJP chief defends 'purification' of Congress chief's Aug. 8 rally venue in Haldwani

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Days after Union Minister and former BJP national president J.P. Nadda condemned the purification of Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge's rally venue in Haldwani, Uttarakhand BJP president Mahendra Bhatt on Wednesday defended the ritual, saying "the place was polluted with slogans".

Mr. Kharge addressed the Vijay Shankhnaad rally at Haldwani's Ramlila ground on August 8. Two days later, members of the Shri Ram Sena reportedly performed a shuddhikaran havan (purification ritual) at the same site.

In the Rajya Sabha, earlier this month, Mr. Kharge demanded the arrest of those behind the 'purification', while the party's in-charge Kumari Selja and



Uttarakhand BJP president Mahendra Bhatt. File Photo: https://en.wikipedia.org

PCC chief Ganesh Godiyal accused the BJP of displaying an "anti-Dalit mindset". The Congress also alleged that those who performed the purification were associated with the BJP.

Allegation rejected

Responding to Mr. Kharge in Parliament, Mr. Nadda rejected the allegation that the BJP had organised the ritual, saying the party did not support such activities.

Mr. Nadda added that the matter would be looked into and expressed regret if Mr. Kharge's sentiments had been hurt.

Speaking to the media after an event in Mussoorie, Mr. Bhatt said criticism over the ritual was being exaggerated by the Opposition for political gain. He argued that the sanctity of a religious and cultural venue must be respected by everyone.

'Place was polluted'

"Those who have no real issues are the ones who raise matters that only damage and divide the society. Khargeji's rally was held in Haldwani. The Ramlila ground there was defiled. At a place where there is a Ram temple, slogans were raised that should not have been raised. The place was polluted, and then it was purified," said Mr. Bhatt.

T.N. SC youth's death: 6 police officers named as accused

The Hindu Bureau
SIVAGANGA

The CB-CID charge sheet filed in the Scheduled Caste youth Akash Delison's custodial death case revealed that a murder case has been registered against six policemen, including a police inspector.

Delison, from Krishnarajapuram in Sivaganga district, was arrested on March 5 in connection with a case in which two people were hacked during a dispute in Manamadurai. Delison was admitted to the Madurai Government Rajaji Hospital with injuries, but he died at the hospital.

The police had claimed that he was injured after falling from a bridge while trying to escape arrest. However, alleging that he died due to police assault, his relatives had staged continuous protests.

SP promises aid for women; to reopen 26,000 schools shut in U.P. if voted to power in 2027

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The Samajwadi Party (SP) on Wednesday said it would implement a 'Stree Saman Samridhhi Yojana' in Uttar Pradesh under which each woman would receive ₹40,000 every year, if the party is voted to power in the 2027 poll.

Addressing a press conference alongside SP president Akhilesh Yadav, party MP Dimple Yadav said, "Women's power will develop not merely by talking about it, but by giving women true representation. Respect and prosperity of every woman included in the PDA as 'Aadhi Abadi (half the population, or women) is our resolve," she said.

PDA is a political acronym coined by the party chief representing marginalised and backward



SP chief Akhilesh Yadav with party MP Dimple Yadav during a press conference in Lucknow on Wednesday. PTI

communities.

The Mainpuri MP said the word 'stree' (woman) had been chosen as it represents the gender without restricting it to any particular age group. "Therefore, the scheme can apply to women of all ages to help them become economically stronger," she said, adding that it would be implemented in phases and its functioning would be assessed periodically.

The SP president announced that over 26,000

schools shut down across the State during the merger process will be reopened if the SP forms the government.

Laptops for students

"Over 26,000 primary schools that have been shut down will be reopened. Someone who is suffering, sad, and humiliated, is PDA. In the future, girls who pass intermediate will be given laptops and given the opportunity to move ahead," Mr. Yadav said.

Odisha rights panel orders probe into wrong parents' names in documents of orphan boy

Satyasundar Barik
BHUBANESWAR

What is harder in life - having no parents or having different names recorded as parents in official documents? Praveen (name changed), an orphan boy from Odisha, has learnt the answer the hard way.

Raised in childcare institutions, Praveen fought against the odds to make his way to Gangadhar Mehler University, Sambalpur, one of Odisha's premier higher education institutions. But discrepancies in the names of his parents recorded in his certificates and Aadhaar card have deprived him of government assistance, casting a shadow over both his identity and education.

Taking note of his or-



Discrepancies between his certificates and Aadhaar card deprived him of govt. assistance, said the orphan. PHOTO FOR REPRESENTATION

deal, the Odisha Human Rights Commission (OHRC) has directed the Sundargarh district administration to probe how the discrepancies arose and explore remedial measures to correct his records.

When Praveen was five, someone left him at the gate of Sarbabhoutik Shishu Seba Ashram in Rourkela. The childcare in-

stitution was closed in 2012 for reasons that remain unclear, following which he was shifted to Rourkela Sishu Bhavan.

"At Sishu Bhavan, the names Munna Ekka and Kan Ekka were recorded as my father and mother. But when my Aadhaar card was made, P.K. Senapati, the superintendent of the institution, was recorded

as my father. My ordeal began there," Praveen recalled.

He alleged that the discrepancies between his certificates and Aadhaar card deprived him of government assistance meant for orphans and persons with disabilities. Praveen has a hearing disability.

Admission denied

After matriculation, he was denied admission when he sought to pursue Plus Two at Sundargarh Government College. The intervention of the Sundargarh District Collector eventually resolved the issue.

Praveen said he repeatedly approached the authorities, drawing attention to the discrepancies in his records, but no corrective action was taken.

ITA calls for targeted invention to safeguard 'troubled' Darjeeling and Dooars tea industry

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Seeking a revival and sustainable development of the tea industry in North Bengal, the Indian Tea Association (ITA) on Wednesday published two White Papers on Darjeeling and Dooars and Terai tea industry.

The Darjeeling White Paper, in particular, highlighted the sharp decline in production - from 14.49 million kg in 1990 to 5.6 million kg in 2025 - and called for urgent, targeted intervention to safeguard the globally recognised GI heritage of Darjeeling tea.

"The Darjeeling White Paper proposes an indicative annual financial support package of approximately ₹113 crore, covering



The Darjeeling White Paper highlighted sharp decline in production from 14.49 million kg in 1990 to 5.6 million kg in 2025. FILE PHOTO

areas such as orthodox tea production, working capital interest support, transport, mechanisation, social security support, rejuvenation and factory modernisation," a press statement by ITA said.

The White Paper on Dooars and Terai tea industry pointed out a market

asymmetry where small tea growers, who account for 68% of the State's production, operate without comparable statutory welfare obligations, while organised estates bear the full burden of housing, health care and compliance costs, creating a dual-cost environment that depresses

auction prices and threatens the organised sector's survival.

Over the past few weeks, the representatives of ITA met State's Industry Minister Tapas Roy, Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta and Subrata Gupta, adviser to Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari.

Restoration road map

"The White Papers comprehensively examine the structural, financial, climatic, labour and market-related challenges confronting these two iconic tea-growing areas and set out a road-map of policy interventions aimed at restoring competitiveness, strengthening sustainability, protecting livelihoods and promoting long-term investment," the ITA statement said.



INBRIEF



Naidu asks officials to roll out Sanjeevani project from Jan. 1

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu has directed officials to roll out the Sanjeevani project, aimed at strengthening healthcare services through digital health records and Artificial Intelligence-based interventions, across Andhra Pradesh from January 1, 2027. Reviewing the project with the officials on Wednesday, Mr. Naidu said the initiative should be implemented effectively to bring about a major transformation in healthcare delivery.

Hyderabad firm gets ₹1,600 crore order from Rolls-Royce

Aerospace and defence components maker Sigma Advanced Systems, a Hyderabad-based company, said it has secured a nearly £125 million (around ₹1,600 crore) long-term contract from Rolls-Royce through its UK subsidiary Bromford Precision Solutions. Under the agreement, Bromford will manufacture various critical engine structures at Sigma's India and UK manufacturing facilities.

HC quashes charges against homestay owner in rape case

The Karnataka High Court has quashed criminal proceedings against the owner of a homestay in Kodagu, who was accused of failing to report to the police the alleged rape of a U.S. national at his property in April and not maintaining registration form about her stay. The court found that the petitioner was under no statutory obligation to report the alleged sexual assault, distinguishing the case from statutes like the POCSO, which expressly create such a duty on anyone who has the knowledge of such offences.

Minister facing graft charges may quit Karnataka Cabinet

Opposition has been demanding his resignation over his alleged role in Valmiki scam; Governor has sought clarity on his continuation; issue may come up during CM's meet with Cong. top brass

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

A day after the BJP and the JD(S) announced a *padayatra* from September 1, reports have emerged that Planning and Statistics Minister B. Nagendra is likely to resign from the Karnataka Cabinet.

The Opposition has been demanding Mr. Nagendra's resignation over his alleged role in the embezzlement of funds from the Maharshi Valmiki Scheduled Tribe Development Corporation, an issue that dominated the recently concluded legislature session.

The possibility of Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot



BJP workers demanding the resignation of Minister B. Nagendra over his alleged involvement in the scam on Monday. FILE PHOTO

granting sanction for Mr. Nagendra's prosecution, following a plea by the CBI, is also believed to have prompted the Minister to consider stepping down. The Governor has reportedly written to the State Cabinet seeking clarity on Mr. Nagendra's continua-

tion in the Ministry. The Enforcement Directorate has already filed a chargesheet in the alleged multi-crore scam in the Corporation.

Sources in the Congress told *The Hindu* that Mr. Nagendra had spoken to Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar

and expressed his desire to resign. To a question from presspersons on the possibility of Mr. Nagendra's resignation, Mr. Shivakumar said, "There is no such proposal at the moment. All party workers, MLAs and Ministers are disciplined soldiers of the party. We have faith in his leadership."

Mr. Shivakumar is scheduled to travel to Delhi on Thursday, where the issue of Mr. Nagendra's resignation is expected to figure in his discussions with top brass of the party including Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge.

He is also likely to seek approval for filling a vacant Cabinet position with a woman legislator.

Six dead as bus rams truck in Telangana

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Six passengers were killed and 12 injured when a bus rammed into a container truck carrying electric poles near Kodad in Telangana early on Wednesday.

The accident occurred when the private bus, operated by Fresh Bus, was travelling from Hyderabad to Eluru via Vijayawada.

The bus rammed the

rear of a truck, reportedly while speeding to overtake another vehicle.

The impact caused the poles from the truck to enter the bus, crushing the driver and a portion of the passenger compartment, the police said.

Expressing shock over the incident, Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy instructed officials to extend all necessary assistance to the victims.

Missing A.P. fishermen found in West Bengal

The Hindu Bureau
ODALAREVU

Seven fishermen from Andhra Pradesh, who went missing in the sea on August 7, were found near Shankarpur fishing harbour off the West Bengal coast on Wednesday.

Contact was lost with the fishermen on August 7 after they went deep-sea fishing off the Andhra Pradesh coast. Navy and Coast

Guard had been conducting search operations since August 17.

On Wednesday, local fishermen found the missing fishermen in their boat near the Shankarpur fishing harbour. The missing fishermen said that they were stranded at sea after the engine of the boat developed a snag.

Officials are in touch with the Bengal authorities to ensure their safe return.

Telangana cyber bureau helps man get back ₹85 lakh lost in scam

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The Telangana Cyber Security Bureau has successfully recovered the entire ₹85.20 lakh siphoned off from an 85-year-old retired bank employee who fell victim to an elaborate digital arrest scam.

According to the police, the victim was contacted by a caller posing as an officer of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) on August 21. The fraudster, speaking in Telugu and appearing on a video call dressed in uniform, falsely claimed that the victim's Aadhaar details had been misused to open bank accounts and carry out fraudulent transactions.

'Threatened the victim'

The caller threatened the victim and warned him against speaking to anyone about the matter, saying that uniformed police officers would otherwise arrive at his home, causing social embarrassment and further legal trouble. The victim transferred ₹85,20,000 to a bank account specified by the fraudster, under the pretext that the money was needed for "RBI verification".

The scam began to unravel when the caller demanded an additional ₹42 lakh, prompting the victim to grow suspicious. He promptly filed a complaint on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal.

Acting swiftly, the TGCSB officers traced the money trail and froze the suspect account held with IDFC Bank's Coimbatore branch, securing the entire defrauded amount.

Onam vibe



In sync: Devotees perform Thiruvathira dance, also known as Kaikottikali, at the eastern entrance of Sree Padmanabhaswamy Temple as part of the Thiruvonam celebrations, in Thiruvananthapuram on Wednesday. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

Tusker Abhimanyu bids adieu to Dasara duties

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

The iconic tusker Abhimanyu, who carried the golden howdah six times in a row during the Jamboo Savari and remained an integral part of Mysuru Dasara for over two decades, on Wednesday bid adieu to his Dasara responsibilities.

He was accorded a ceremonial send-off during the *Gajapayana* at Veeranahosahalli, on the outskirts of the Nagarahole Tiger Reserve. The *Gajapayana* marks the formal beginning of preparations for the Mysuru Dasara festivities.

Abhimanyu is regarded



Royal send off: Legendary elephant Abhimanyu receiving a ceremonial farewell in Karnataka on Wednesday. M.A. SRIRAM

as one of the celebrated members of the Dasara jumbo squad and the Forest Department. Abhimanyu's mahout and kavadi,

Vasanth and Karthik, also bid an emotional farewell to the tusker who will no longer be part of the Dasara festivities from this year.

In Telangana, it takes a village to save a beloved tree

Swathi Vadlamudi
HYDERABAD

In a world where trees are considered a hindrance to development, a village in Telangana is standing by the tree they loved and cherished for decades.

Residents of Pedda Thandrapadu, a village in Jogulamba Gadwal district, have forged a united front against attempts to pull down a peepal tree located inside the premises of a private property.

The villagers approached the authorities at the mandal level during the recently held *Prajavani* programme, and submitted a representation seeking protection of the peepal tree at the village centre, which they claimed was encroached upon by illegal structures.

"There was a cement platform raised around the



Residents have forged a united front against attempts to pull down a peepal tree located inside a private property. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

tree earlier, where people used to relax and conduct village meetings. But the platform was demolished later, and a compound wall was constructed enclosing the tree," said a villager who did not wish to be named.

Matters got worse when the property owner sought

permission from the Forest Department to fell the tree, calling it a hazard.

Upon getting wind of the application, the villagers banded together to object to the move.

They made representations to the police, the Forest Range Officer, the Mandal Revenue Officer, the

Mandal Parishad Development Officer, the District Collector and the National Green Tribunal, requesting them to stop the felling.

'Part of our lives'

"The tree is a part of our lives. For generations, we have been using its *Paala Komma* (sacred branch) in various rituals, such as weddings. We seek a comprehensive inquiry into how the tree was encroached upon," the petitioners said, demanding that the peepal be declared a 'heritage tree'.

Kurva China Ramudu, an 85-year-old villager, says he had witnessed the tree being planted during his childhood, which makes it easily about 70-75 years old.

Jangam Bhogeshwar Rao, the owner who submitted the felling application, said his parents

bought the piece of land during the 1960s, which was later divided among the siblings.

"I got the platform demolished and constructed the wall around it because the platform was attracting drunkards and vagabonds. Villagers who are protesting now had helped me construct the wall. Now, an issue is being made out of it purely due to personal rivalries," he said.

He says he is ready to bear the cost of translocation if needed. However, the root mass of the tree would be so huge that it would pose a danger to the structural stability of the house if a translocation is attempted.

Forest Range Officer Parvez Ahmed said permission had not yet been granted for felling of the tree due to objections by the villagers.

Kerala HC issues norms for detention before formal arrest

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court recently held that detention for fact-finding or to aid an investigation does not amount to unlawful arrest in certain circumstances.

It found that the law recognised situations where a person could be detained without the procedural formality of arrest, provided that the detention was based on reasonable suspicion or credible information. In such cases, the mandatory requirement to produce the accused before a Magistrate within 24 hours would begin only once the arrest was formally recorded, it said.

The court also issued

guidelines to ensure detention before formal arrest is enforced in accordance with constitutional rights. It stated that notice must be issued before any detention for investigation.

The investigating agency must record the precise time of initial detention and formal arrest. After detention, the accused should be produced before a Magistrate within 24 hours. The arrestee and a relative, friend, or nominated person must be informed of the grounds for arrest immediately upon detention.

It was hearing pleas where the accused had said that they were detained much before their formal arrest.

FAITH

Ramayana, the *adi kavya*

Rama avatara is the only one which is dealt with in a literary work, namely Valmiki Ramayana. There are many works about Krishna avatara, but these are not exclusively about Krishna, said M.A. Venkatakrishnan in a discourse. Srimad Bhagavatam deals with many things, and only the tenth *skanda* is about Krishna. Vishnu Purana also talks about Krishna avatara, but only the fifth *amsa* (section) is about Krishna. Valmiki's work is called *adi kavya*, because it is the first work to have been written in kavya style. The Vedas do not have an author. Ramayana is the first work to come after the Vedas and that is why it is called *adi kavya*. The first four chapters are like an introduction. Only in the fifth chapter, we learn about Ayodhya and its king Dasaratha.

Valmiki performed rigorous penance. There are eight stages in penance. These stages involve control of the senses, control of the mind, breath control, meditation, and remaining seated continuously, without getting up for any reason. Valmiki went through all these stages and because he never moved, a termite hill came up around him. When his *tapas* ended, he broke the hill to come out. Valmika means termite hill. Because the sage came out of a termite hill, he came to be known as Valmiki. He began writing his story when Rama was ruling as king of Ayodhya and before Sita was banished by Rama. Valmiki had already met Rama, and knew about Him. But when Narada visits him, he asks the latter who is the ideal man alive at that time, who has 16 great qualities. Valmiki knows that only Rama possesses these qualities, and that Narada is going to tell him so.

Why India's R&D system needs a map of where funds really go

Moumita Koley



167 years since the world's first commercially successful oil well...



Arctic 'jungles' offer critical insights into climate studies

A IN-X

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A IN-X



Restoring lakes by going beyond quick fixes

Covering nearly 6% of the planet’s surface, wetlands – including urban lakes – are among the most productive ecosystems on Earth. They store a disproportionately large share of the world’s carbon, often outperforming terrestrial forests per unit area. Beyond carbon sequestration, they contribute immensely to biodiversity, climate regulation, and human well-being. Yet today, lakes are disappearing at an alarming pace. Many of our remaining urban wetlands are either biologically dead or heavily eutrophic. In losing them, cities are systematically eroding their natural defences against climate change, undermining public health, and threatening the very foundations of urban liveability.

The widespread destruction of water bodies is a direct consequence of rapid, unplanned urbanisation. As land pressure intensifies in crowded localities, developers and municipal bodies view these natural landscapes as vacant land rather than critical ecological infrastructure. This mindset makes lakes highly vulnerable to encroachment and systemic disappearance.

Compounding this physical destruction is a deep-rooted institutional and public apathy. Heavily polluted water bodies have become convenient spots for untreated sewage, industrial effluents, and municipal solid waste. This collective inaction reveals a grim truth: lakes are dying not only because they are encroached upon, but because they are taken for granted.

The sheer volume of data capturing this damage is overwhelming. Reports by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) have flagged large-scale shrinkage in J&K, including over 500 lakes since 1967. Down south, the crisis is equally acute. Hyderabad lost roughly 61% of its lake area since 1979, with 268 water bodies completely disappearing between 2002-2012 as detailed in one study. As cities



Mohan Chandra Pargaien

Adviser to SCCL, Telangana and former Indian forest officer with over three decades of experience in natural resource management

In cities such as Hyderabad, Bengaluru, and Mumbai, peri-urban land that once served as agricultural fields or natural lake catchments has mutated into prime real estate

grapple with intensifying heat islands and unpredictable urban flooding, there is a desperate need to treat these lifelines as ‘urban climate buffers’ and ‘sponge systems’ rather than as liabilities.

Taken for granted

Half a century ago, land in Indian cities was relatively affordable, urban expansion was moderate, and lakes were respected for their functional civic assets. Today, land prices have multiplied manifold in the past five decades. In cities such as Hyderabad, Bengaluru, and Mumbai, peri-urban land that once served as agricultural fields or natural lake catchments has mutated into prime real estate. This exponential spike has transformed lakes into a perceived “opportunity cost.” Encroachment becomes economically incentivised, leading to wetlands being filled, fragmented, and repurposed for housing, highways, and commercial complexes.

India’s recent achievement of expanding its tally of designated Ramsar sites reflects a formal, high-level recognition of wetland conservation. However, international designations must not be mistaken for local conservation success. On the ground, the reality remains fiercely complex, plagued by ambiguous boundaries, ongoing encroachment, and disrupted catchment areas. While initiatives such as the Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation, the Jal Shakti Abhiyan, and Mission Amrit Sarovar provide useful policy skeletons, their on-the-ground impact is routinely diluted.

This failure stems from fragmented accountability, weak inter-departmental coordination, and a deeply flawed tendency to prioritise beautification over genuine ecological recovery. Municipal bodies often prioritise visible beautification over ecological repair – promenades, lighting, and fencing – while ignoring feeder channels, catchments, and water quality.

Real restoration demands raw institutional intent, as demonstrated by a recent Telangana initiative – the newly formed Hyderabad Disaster Response and Asset Protection Agency (HYDRAA). The agency has actively reclaimed encroached lakebeds, cleared illegal structures within Full Tank Level zones, and initiated restoration work across dozens of water bodies. Crucially, by desilting long-blocked feeder channels and restoring natural hydrological flows, the agency nearly doubled the water spread of the severely choked Nalla Cheruvu from 16 to 30 acres.

In parallel with State action, grassroots citizen movements have also shown exceptional results from community involvement. Passionate “lake champions” in Bengaluru and Hyderabad have successfully revived dying water bodies such as in Puttenahalli, Jakkur, and Kudikunta.

But these successes remain too isolated. Without institutionalised legal backing, sustained state funding, and unyielding statutory enforcement, local wins will remain exceptions rather than becoming a replicating model.

Beyond quick fixes

India’s urban future is shaped by a complex crisis of land, law, and governance. Resolving this crisis requires deep structural reform over cosmetic fixes. First, water bodies must be formally integrated into city planning. Second, lake boundaries and catchments need absolute legal protection, with strict, consistent penalties for encroachments. Streamlining fragmented governance under unified, accountable authorities is vital. Finally, citizen engagement must be institutionalised within governance frameworks to ensure permanent local ownership. Cities that reduce lakes to landscaped backdrops will eventually pay the price in floods, heat stress, and water scarcity while those that restore them as living ecosystems will secure their resilience in a warming, water-stressed future.

Bengaluru’s risk-averse force

Police have been cautious in their approach to protests, irrespective of who is in power

STATE OF PLAY

K.V. Aditya Bharadwaj

The Bengaluru City Police recently registered a *suo motu* FIR against a woman for holding a placard which read “Umar Khalid Zindabad”, “Sharjeel Imam Zindabad” at a students’ protest. Neha Bora, National President of the All India Students’ Association, during her visit to Bengaluru last week, slammed the Congress government in Karnataka for its action and said that parties who claim to be against the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) must lead by example rather than pay lip service.

This is not an isolated incident. Even as senior Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi have been vocal about Israel’s war on Palestine, the Bengaluru Police booked three *suo motu* FIRs against pro-Palestine demonstrators. Two of these have been quashed by the High Court of Karnataka. Police even disrupted multiple indoor meetings where pro-Palestine films and issues were being discussed. While no police permission is needed for indoor meetings, the unwritten rule in Bengaluru seems to be that the local police need to be kept in the loop.

Extreme caution

Irrespective of the party in power, the Bengaluru City Police have been accused of being “risk averse” regarding protests and dissent. The police have often weaponised the Licensing and Regulation of Protests, Demonstrations and Protest Marches (Bengaluru City) Order, 2021, which mandated that all protests can be held only at Freedom Park.

The order came in response to a *suo motu* PIL taken



up by the High Court over protests causing traffic disruptions. Significantly, it also came close on the heels of protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, during the BJP’s tenure, when the pavement outside a mosque called Bilal Bagh turned into a site of protest. Several activists argue that protests being restricted to Freedom Park are ghettoised and invisibilised. A campaign to reverse the 2021 order, after the Congress came to power in 2023, has not yielded any results.

The police argue that they did not allow pro-Palestine protests, for if they had, right-wing groups too would have held pro-Israel demonstrations and the situation may have escalated. Recently, stand-up comic Kunal Kamra had to shift his stand-up show at a venue in Whitefield, after a little-known Hindutva outfit opposed it. Earlier, shows by stand-up comic Munnawar Faruqui were cancelled twice during the BJP regime following a similar campaign.

Azim Premji University recently lodged a criminal complaint against its own students for holding a discussion on the 1991 Kunan Poshpora incident in Kashmir without prior approval from the administration, after activists from the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad barged in and vandalised the University’s campus. Persistent campaigns by Hindutva groups prompting the police to either deny permis-

sion or try to make venues back out are not uncommon.

In a rare instance, recently, the police gave security for a discussion on Umar Khalid’s book at the Bangalore International Centre, after the organisers refused to back down despite a campaign. However, the police registered a *suo motu* FIR against a woman for holding a placard hailing Umar Khalid, following a shrill campaign by Kannada television news media.

A slow approach

Despite the Congress coming to power with a thumping majority in 2023, a rare feat in Karnataka in decades, it has been slow in countering the Hindutva agenda, for fear of what has been called “playing into the hands of the BJP.”

For instance, following the new Home Minister Priyank Kharge’s face-off with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) over it not being registered and that it should take government’s permission before using public spaces, the State Cabinet recently approved the Karnataka Regulation of Use of Government Premises and Public Property Bill, 2026. However, it was not tabled in the just-concluded legislature session. Even as Mr. Kharge insisted on the RSS taking permission for their Vijaydashmi route march in his constituency Chittapur in 2025, the RSS was allowed to hold route marches in 100 places to mark its centenary.

Neither has the Congress repealed the two “communal laws” – the Karnataka Prevention of Slaughter and Preservation of Cattle Act, 2020, and the Karnataka Protection of Right to Freedom of Religion Act, 2022 – it promised to roll back in its 2023 manifesto.

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Deletions in recent SIRs suggest arbitrary application of reasons

In Karnataka and Telangana, the draft SIR rolls reveal that deletions for which reasons were marked as ‘Shifted’ and ‘Absent’ have been applied erratically

DATA POINT

Pon Vasanth B.A.

The draft electoral rolls released after the enumeration phase of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise in Telangana and Karnataka have not only raised concerns of aggressive deletions, but analysis indicates wide variations and arbitrariness in the reasons given for the deletion of names.

The two States have seen the highest share of deletions in the draft SIR rolls among the major States. Telangana and Karnataka, which had 3.38 crore and 5.54 crore electors before the SIR respectively, saw roughly one-fifth of their rolls getting culled. *The Hindu* has reported on the alarming levels of deletions in many of the constituencies in the two States.

A reason-wise analysis of the data showed extremes in the application of the four broad reasons cited for deletions – Shifted (or Permanently Shifted), Absent, Deceased, and Duplicate.

Before discussing the apparent arbitrariness of the application of these reasons, it is to be noted that the Election Commission (EC) has not offered clarity in any of its SIR-related notifications about when the officials – particularly the Booth-level Officers (BLOs) working on the ground – should mark an elector as ‘Shifted’ and when as ‘Absent’. The EC’s Manual on Electoral Rolls (2023), which is supposed to be the rule book to follow for all types of electoral roll revision, states that “an absentee voter is that person who is found to be absent for a limited period from place of his ordinary residence where he is enrolled as an elector. An absentee may be with family or without family. But his name cannot be deleted, as in the existing law, a person absenting himself temporarily from his place of ordinarily residence shall not, by reason thereof, cease to be ordinarily

resident therein.” This definition raises the question as to whether an elector found to be ‘Absent’ during enumeration should be deleted in the first place.

Interestingly, the EC has never officially made public the breakdown of ‘Shifted’ and ‘Absent’ in total deletions. It has combined the two categories and presented only the aggregate numbers for every State where the SIR has happened. The breakdown has been derived by journalists and members of the civil society by processing the thousands of lists containing details of deleted electors.

Table 1 and **Table 2** show a few constituencies from Telangana and Karnataka, which stand out as examples of the inexplicable application of reasons for deletions.

For instance, both Jubilee Hills and Nizamabad (Urban) are urban constituencies of comparable size in Telangana. Of the 1,79,510 names deleted in Jubilee Hills, 1,48,859 (83%) were marked as ‘Shifted’, but only 15,000 were found to be ‘Absent’. In Nizamabad (Urban), however, of the 83,282 deletions, officials found 50,307 to be ‘Absent’. The outlier case was the reserved constituency Nakrekal (SC), where 20,169 names were deleted, but not a single person was found to be ‘Absent’.

In Karnataka, Hebbal saw 1.3 lakh deletions, of which an astounding 1.14 lakh (87%) were marked as ‘Shifted’, but only 287 were found to be ‘Absent’. The Hubli-Dharwad-East constituency, in contrast recorded, roughly 25,000 of its 47,000 as ‘Absent’. Bommanahalli saw 2.65 lakh deletions, which is 54.8% of its electorate. However, only about 9,700 were found to be deceased.

Table 3 and **Table 4** show the wide variations between different categories of reasons for every 1,000 electors deleted in the draft rolls. A coherent and uniform application of a well-defined enumeration exercise is unlikely to show such extremities.

Extremities in deletions

The tables capture the seeming arbitrariness in the reasons used for deletion of large number of electors in Telangana and Karnataka. The values in Tables 3 and 4 are reason-wise numbers, calculated as deletions per 1,000 electors in the rolls before SIR

TABLE 1: A few constituencies in **Telangana** that reveal implausible variations in the reasons for which electors were deleted

Constituency	Electors before SIR	Deletions (%)	Shifted (%)	Absent (%)	Deceased (%)	Duplicate (%)	Why is it odd?
Jubilee Hills	4.07 lakh	44.1	82.9	8.4	4.6	4.1	Of 1.78 lakh deletions, 829 per 1,000 were ‘Shifted’, but only 84 were ‘Absent’
Nizamabad (Urban)	3.08 lakh	27.0	18.1	60.4	6.4	14.5	Inverse of Jubilee hills. Of the 83,000 deletions, 604 per 1,000 were marked as ‘Absent’, but only 181 as ‘Shifted’
Nakrekal (SC)	2.59 lakh	7.8	58.0	0.0	32.3	9.6	20,169 deletions, but not a single one was found to be ‘Absent’
Palakurthi	2.61 lakh	7.6	42.4	1.5	39.4	16.7	8,000 of roughly 20,000 deletions were ‘Deceased’ — highest in the State
Sanathnagar	2.54 lakh	44.9	82.7	9.8	3.7	3.8	Inverse of Palakurthi. Of the 1.14 lakh deletions, only 40 per 1,000 were ‘Deceased’
Ramagundam	2.14 lakh	14.4	28.6	1.0	15.4	55.0	Highest proportion of ‘Duplicates’. 550 per 1,000 deletions
Malkajgiri	5.13 lakh	37.6	77.3	12.9	8.3	1.4	Inverse of Ramagundam. Of the 1.93 lakh deletions, only 14 per 1,000 were ‘Duplicates’

TABLE 2: A few constituencies in **Karnataka**, where similar patterns of drastic differences in the reasons could be observed

Constituency	Electors before SIR	Deletions (%)	Shifted (%)	Absent (%)	Deceased (%)	Duplicate (%)	Why is it odd?
Hebbal	3.02 lakh	43.2	87.2	0.2	8.7	3.8	1.3 lakh deleted. 870 per 1,000 marked as ‘Shifted’, but only 2 per 1,000 ‘Absent’
Hubli-Dharwad-East	2.28 lakh	20.6	15.4	53.3	20.4	10.9	Inverse of Hebbal. 533 per 1,000 marked as ‘Absent’, but only 154 per 1,000 as ‘Shifted’
Arakalgud	2.37 lakh	9.7	40.1	3.3	46.3	10.3	Nearly half of roughly 22,000 deletions were marked as ‘Deceased’
Bommanahalli	4.85 lakh	54.8	50.3	37.7	3.7	8.3	Inverse of Arakalgud. Saw 55% of its electoral rolls culled, but only 37 per 1,000 deletions were marked as ‘Deceased’
Kanakagiri	2.32 lakh	10.2	46.9	0.7	20.6	31.7	7,500 of 23,000 deletions marked as ‘Duplicates’ – highest share of ‘Duplicates’
Rajajinagar	2.1 lakh	47.9	82.2	7.3	8.3	2.2	Inverse of Kanakagiri. One lakh deletions, but only 2,200 marked as ‘Duplicate’

TABLE 3: The reason-wise variations in deletions in **Telangana** between urban and rural constituencies

Urban (33 constituencies). Values per 1000 electors pre-SIR					
Reason	Average	Min	Max	Max / Min	
Deceased	28.86	16.42	48.10	2.9	
Duplicate	22.29	5.29	78.99	14.9	
Shifted	239.04	41.17	371.59	9.0	
Absent	67.82	1.38	163.20	118.0	

Rural (86 constituencies). Values per 1000 electors pre-SIR					
Reason	Average	Min	Max	Max / Min	
Deceased	27.09	14.72	44.26	3.0	
Duplicate	19.18	5.03	44.24	8.8	
Shifted	62.10	18.33	123.94	6.8	
Absent	13.14	0.00	88.93	n/a (min = 0)	

TABLE 4: The reason-wise variations in deletions in **Karnataka** between urban and rural constituencies

Urban (57 constituencies). Values per 1,000 electors pre-SIR					
Reason	Average	Min	Max	Max / Min	
Deceased	32.90	14.02	57.46	4.1	
Duplicate	30.07	5.07	92.80	18.3	
Shifted	205.68	31.69	393.36	12.4	
Absent	61.44	0.95	206.60	217.3	

Rural (167 constituencies). Values per 1,000 electors pre-SIR					
Reason	Average	Min	Max	Max / Min	
Deceased	28.46	14.55	52.44	3.6	
Duplicate	14.39	4.09	36.04	8.8	
Shifted	63.94	18.34	246.04	13.4	
Absent	9.90	0.01	60.21	7450.0	

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO AUGUST 27, 1976

Chances on life on Mars

Pasadena, California, August 26: America’s Viking-I Mars probe has sent back another clear reading that there could be life in the Martian soil but space scientists said they were still sceptical about the results.

The Viking project biologist, Dr. Orman Horowitz, said the latest readings sent yesterday “certainly increase the chance” that there are microscopic forms of life in the red Mars soil.

According to results announced at a press conference here all three biological tests in the tiny Viking laboratory now show there could be life on the planet.

“I really don’t understand it, but I’m overwhelmed,” said the Viking project scientist, Dr. Gerard Soffen.

The latest experiment was a controlled test on a Martian soil sample which had already signalled it could contain as many living organisms as soil in the Antarctic region on earth. Under the test, the soil sample is cooked to a high temperature to kill any organisms in it.

If the sample is dead when it is retested – as happened with the controlled test announced on Tuesday – then the chances are that the initial readings were caused by biology and not by chemistry, scientists say. Dr. Horowitz said: “if we had observed these results in laboratories on earth we would have concluded that it was weak but definitely positive biological signal.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 27, 1926

Entrance into the Army

Simla, August 26: A communique states: – With the object of obtaining some idea of what suitable material for the army is to be found in Indian universities, a sub-committee of the Indian Sandhurst Committee, consisting of Lieut-General Sir Andrew Skeen, Chairman, Dr. Ziauddin Ahmed and Captain Bala Sahib Dafle, recently made a tour of representative universities in all parts of India.

Bombay, Poona, Madras, Calcutta, Benares and Allahabad universities were visited.

The Punjab University could not be seen on this occasion as its vacation is now in progress.

During the course of this tour, it became apparent that the method of obtaining entrance to officer ranks was still comparatively little known in spite of the announcements on the subject which have appeared in the press from time to time.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Value of U.S. imports on which Canada has imposed tariffs

20 in \$ billion. Canada hit back at the U.S. on Tuesday with retaliatory tariffs on about \$20 billion worth of annual imports and rolled out aid for businesses and workers, matching the latest duties imposed by the Donald Trump administration dollar-for-dollar. REUTERS

Persons named by India for AFC U20 Asian Cup Qualifiers

23 India on Wednesday named a 23-member squad for the upcoming AFC U20 Asian Cup Qualifiers in Tashkent, after omitting eight players who were called for the national camp. The qualifying tournament will be held in the Uzbek capital from August 31 to September 6. PTI

Amount requested by Italy from EU's SAFE defence funds

8 in € billion. Italy has requested €8 billion from the European Union's SAFE funding programme, a source said on Wednesday, confirming earlier media reports. The SAFE instrument is a joint borrowing scheme backed by the EU aimed at boosting the bloc's defence capabilities. REUTERS

Private pharmacies under RGHS scheme facing action

215 Authorities have temporarily suspended 215 private pharmacies from processing transactions under the Rajasthan Government Health Scheme (RGHS) for alleged negligence and delays in dispensing medicines, officials said on Wednesday. PTI

Number of major South Delhi flyovers repaired by PWD

3 The Public Works Department (PWD) is planning to undertake repair and maintenance work on stretches of three major South Delhi flyovers, including Nehru Nagar, the AIIMS loops and Barapullah Phase 1, officials said on Wednesday. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Why was Parandur airport scrapped?

What were the main objections to the Parandur site? How much land had been acquired? What approvals had the plan secured? Why does Chennai need another airport? What will Terminal 5 add to Chennai airport's capacity? How soon can Chennai get a second airport?

EXPLAINER

Sunitha Sekar

The story so far:

Four years after it was announced, one of the most anticipated and controversial projects for Chennai city, the second airport proposed at Parandur, has now been scrapped by the Tamil Nadu government. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay announced in the State Assembly on August 24 that the government would drop the project and look for an alternative site to build Chennai's second airport.

Meanwhile, the Airports Authority of India will construct Terminal 5 in the northwestern area of the airport, which passengers will be able to access via an elevated corridor. The existing Chennai airport at Meenambakkam handles 30 million passengers a year. With the ongoing construction of Terminal 3, which will also handle international flights along with Terminal 2, the airport's capacity will increase to 35 million passengers a year. If Terminal 5 is also completed, the airport's capacity will rise further to 55 million passengers a year.

When did the search begin?

The plan for a second airport for Chennai dates back to 1998, when the Ministry of Civil Aviation announced that the project was under consideration. The then Chief Minister, M. Karunanidhi, wrote to Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee, requesting him to expedite the project's clearance. A site 10 km south of Meenambakkam was earmarked for the airport, which was to be developed under the Build-Own-Operate-Transfer model.

A year later, the Centre gave its nod for the project, which was planned to come up on 3,000 acres at an estimated cost of ₹2,000 crore. However, the project did not take off. In 2007, the Tamil Nadu government announced yet again that a second airport would be built, this time



The Tamil Nadu government revived the plan for a second airport in 2022 and announced that it would be built at Parandur in Kancheepuram district. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

over 4,820 acres at Sriperumbudur, with four runways. The site was emerging as a strong industrial and manufacturing corridor, and an airport there was seen as strategically important for the city's growth. But the project was embroiled in controversy, drawing fierce opposition from political parties and farmers who objected to their land being taken over for the project. The project too failed to progress, and the following decade saw only the existing airport at Meenambakkam undergo Phase I and Phase II modernisation.

The Tamil Nadu government revived the plan for a second airport in 2022 and announced that it would be built at Parandur in Kancheepuram district. Farmers in Ekanapuram, who faced relocation if the project became a reality, began staging protests.

In early 2025, a year after launching his party Tamilaga Vетtri Kazhagam, Mr. Vijay visited the project site at Parandur to show solidarity with the protesting farmers. Keeping his promise, he announced earlier this week that the government would no longer pursue the

Parandur airport project.

Why did Parandur face opposition?

After the project was announced in 2022, landowners in several villages in and around Parandur opposed it, saying it would severely affect their livelihoods. Villagers in Ekanapuram also warned that the project could lead to an environmental disaster. Activists echoed these concerns, pointing out that the proposed site is interspersed with several water bodies. They said the construction of the airport could not only inundate nearby villages but also increase the risk of flooding in Chennai.

How far had the project progressed?

Over the last four years, the Tamil Nadu government secured some major approvals required to commence the project, including site clearance and in-principle approval from the Ministry of Civil Aviation.

Of the 5,846 acres required for the project, the government completed the acquisition of 1,802 acres. The State government, however, had not obtained

environmental clearance or floated bids to find a private operator.

Why does Chennai need another airport?

Nearly a decade ago, Chennai was the third-busiest airport in the country, after New Delhi and Kolkata. However, privately managed airports in Bengaluru and Hyderabad have recorded significant growth over the past decade and have overtaken Chennai to become the country's third- and fourth-busiest airports, respectively.

Bengaluru, in particular, has raised the benchmark for passenger experience, while adding direct flights to Paris, Amsterdam, Munich, Vietnam, Tokyo and the Maldives. Chennai airport, however, has yet to secure direct flights to any of these destinations. Passengers have also raised several concerns about the airport in recent years, including delays in opening a second cab pick-up point and completing Terminal 3, among others.

Industry experts have repeatedly stressed that an airport should no longer be viewed merely as transport infrastructure, but as an economic engine that can draw investments, companies and employment for a city and the State.

With Tamil Nadu turning into a \$1.5-trillion economy in the next 10 years, world-class airport infrastructure is the need of the hour, experts say.

What happens next?

With the Parandur airport project scrapped, the Tamil Nadu government is back to searching for an ideal site for Chennai's second airport. However, experts point out that finding a location without farmlands and water bodies in and around Chennai will be far from easy and that one must also look at the availability of airspace before arriving at a location.

Even if the process begins now, the earliest Chennai could get a second airport would be in five to seven years, depending on how quickly the clearances are granted by the Centre.

THE GIST

Tamil Nadu has scrapped the Parandur airport plan after sustained opposition from farmers over land acquisition, livelihoods and the site's water bodies, and will look for an alternative location.

Chennai's existing airport capacity is being expanded to 55 million passengers with Terminal 3 and the proposed Terminal 5, but experts say a second airport is crucial to support the city's economic growth.

The government now faces the challenge of finding a site with minimal impact on farmlands and water bodies, with a new airport unlikely to be ready for at least five to seven years.

How can States use disaster funds for heatwaves?

Heatwave funding expands, but States must strengthen planning and implementation to use it effectively

Shravan Prabhu

In August 4, the Ministry of Home Affairs told the Lok Sabha that heatwaves and lightning had been added to India's list of notified natural calamities, taking the total list to 14.

The change follows a recommendation by the Sixteenth Finance Commission (FC-XVI) and operational guidelines issued on June 30. Along with the 2024 amendment to the Disaster Mitigation Fund guidelines, the update means heatwaves are now eligible for the full State Disaster Risk Management Fund pool.

Disaster finance in India

Under Article 280 of the Constitution, the Finance Commission recommends arrangements for disaster management funds. The FC-XVI recommended ₹2.04 lakh crore for State disaster funds in the five years between 2026-27 and 2030-31,

nearly 28% more than the previous Commission's allocation.

Of the total fund, ₹1.6 lakh crore goes to the State Disaster Response Fund (SDRF) and the rest to the State Disaster Mitigation Fund (SDMF). The SDRF is meant for response, relief, and reconstruction immediately following a disaster; the SDMF is meant to fund interventions to reduce the risk of a climate event from turning into a disaster, in the longer term.

These funds are available to all States. The FC-XVI has determined the inter-State distribution using a formula comprising a disaster risk index, which takes into account the frequency and intensity of different hazards along with exposure and vulnerability and expenses incurred by States during the previous commission's tenure. The FC-XVI recommended ₹79,406 crore for national disaster funds over the same period and which States can seek when a disaster is severe enough to exceed their own resources, like Kerala

did following the Wayanad landslides in 2024.

Heat has thus far occupied an awkward position in the disaster finance system. A State could notify a heatwave as a 'local disaster' and use the SDRF – but only up to 10% of its annual allocation and after setting separate norms such as the amount of compensation for loss of lives or damage to crops. Other notified disasters such as floods and cyclones faced no such ceiling. The new notification removes this asymmetry.

India's exposure to extreme heat is growing. The author used 35 indicators across climate change, exposure, and vulnerability to estimate that more than 57% of Indian districts, home to roughly three-fourths of the Indian population, face high- to very-high heat risk. The number of hot days per year has increased. The incidence of very warm nights and relative humidity has also risen, reducing the human body's ability to recover after hot days.

What States can fund

The National Disaster Management Authority has asked all States, districts, and cities to develop heat action plans (HAPs), which map heat risk and vulnerability and identify short-, medium-, and long-term interventions. Thus far, 300 cities and districts across 23 heatwave-prone States have HAPs.

Implementation, however, has lagged because of limited technical capacity, competing priorities, and inadequate funding. A 2023 review of HAPs also found that 79% of the plans asked city departments to self-allocate funds.

The new Central notification provides States with two clearer financing options. Under the SDRF, they can provide relief and compensation for heat-related losses. And through the SDMF, they can finance longer-term risk reduction such as cooling shelters and early-warning systems. The respective State Disaster Management Authorities and State Emergency Operations Centre will be the nodal agencies responsible for both funds' corpus.

Next steps

First, heat planning must expand. Twelve States have already notified heatwaves locally but only some 300 cities and districts have HAPs, leaving around 4,800 urban local bodies and 800 districts without them. Heat-specific SDMF guidelines are still awaited, but existing guidelines require risk and vulnerability

assessments before any projects are proposed – precisely the groundwork HAPs are meant to provide.

Second, plans must become fundable projects. States need model mitigation proposals suited to local climate and geography. Many local bodies lack the technical capacity to prepare such proposals. Research institutions, NGOs, and philanthropy could provide technical support and risk capital to help convert plans into appraisable projects.

Third, health surveillance must improve. Relief payouts will now depend on accurate loss-and-damage data. The Health Ministry's current surveillance system covers over 51,000 reporting units and recorded 4,853 heatstroke cases and 20 confirmed heatstroke deaths between March 1 and July 26. But it misses the wider burden from heart, lung, and kidney conditions worsened by heat.

Fourth, States should link heat solutions to other government development schemes by identifying convergence, and use fast, pre-agreed tools like parametric insurance, which pays out automatically once a set temperature threshold is crossed. Similar tools already operate for other hazards; Nagaland, for example, has rainfall insurance that pays out when rainfall levels cross a set threshold. (Shravan Prabhu is Programme Lead at Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) and Coordinator of the GHHIN South Asia Heat & Health Hub)

BIBLIOGRAPHY



GETTY IMAGES

How India’s scam towns built a thriving industry around fraud

Three books trace the journey of India’s cyber fraud industry, from Jamtara and the Mewat belt to global scam operations in Southeast Asia; they examine how cheap mobile data, penury, greed, rapid digitisation and weak law enforcement have allowed the industry to grow and adapt

Aroon Deep

Many people, especially in urban areas, have realised the perils of picking up calls from strangers and giving them their bank account or other personal details after being lured by tempting offers or frightened by threats. Responding to this surge in cybercrime, the government mandated telecom operators to replace caller tunes with public service announcements warning us all to be on guard. A 2020 Netflix series set in Jamtara in Jharkhand had some success; now, we have the first of what is likely to be a subgenre of books studying these scammers’ techniques.

While the scams have caused great distress to those who have lost their hard-earned savings, they have enriched groups of youth beyond their wildest dreams in many villages, from Jamtara to the Mewat belt spanning Rajasthan, Haryana, and Uttar Pradesh. In hitherto forgotten areas, where generations have lived in squalor, palatial houses have cropped up where roads barely reach, and the land isn’t arable.

Motorcycle showrooms with thick order books have emerged, selling models that would otherwise only sell more than once a week in tier-1 showrooms. And it did not take Chitradeep Chakraborty, author of *Jamtara Calling* (Rupa Publications), more than an hour to find someone who was willing to describe the entire ecosystem that allows fraudsters to con unsuspecting victims and make them

part with their savings.

The art of adapting

The book is a good entry point into the way ‘scamming towns’ work. Much of it is about an extended field trip in Jamtara, with a cab driver turning fixer. Chakraborty sparks up lengthy conversations with key operators, while pretending to be an executive from a telecom operator (he doesn’t say which one, but it isn’t hard to hazard a guess). The days-long outing, which he chronicles in this slim volume, sketches a town where desperate circumstances and sudden digitisation gave birth to a cottage industry that operates with impunity. So much impunity, in fact, that nearly every operator he recalls meeting spills out the secrets of his tradecraft – it is usually a man – after a little more than a friendly introduction and a cup of tea.

What Chakraborty finds is that “cybers,” the shorthand that scammers have adopted in this region, constantly adapt to changing circumstances. Scams take place in phases, since awareness about them is spreading fast. In response, their techniques get more sophisticated. When scammers realise that their method of tricking people to give up their one-time passcodes has stopped working, they move on to convincing people, using an ingenious math-based exploit, to give up their ATM cards’ PIN instead. And when that stops working as well, they pretend to be retired Army personnel and start hawking non-existent furniture and bikes on platforms such as OLX and

Quikr. He finds that the local police are happy to turn a blind eye to the whole sordid business as long as they get a share in the profits. But that isn’t the case when scammers make the mistake of fooling a Member of Parliament or a senior bureaucrat; in those cases, the police storm the town and arrest the odd lynchpin. But cases hardly stick, given the clogged criminal justice system and the ability of the nouveau riche scammers to hire expensive legal representation.

Beyond call scams

In *Bharat Bluff* (Roli Books), another breezy read, Soumya Gupta takes a macro view of the economic and legal conditions that permit the industrialisation of scams. For instance, India still does not have a stringent data privacy law in force (the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 comes into force next year). She also examines the broader sweep of dishonesty on the Indian internet, from fake identities on Instagram targeting well-off liberals to Chinese loan apps charging usurious interest (if at all the loans are legitimate to begin with).

Snigdha Poonam’s *Scamlands* (Penguin Viking) widens the scope of studying this fraud. She applies a quasi-pop anthropological lens on the hustlers of Jamtara and elsewhere, refining an approach that she had used with great success in her 2018 book, *Dreamers*. *Scamlands* takes an expansive and meditative approach, trying to probe into the inner lives of the newly rich and their devastated victims alike. The book also

takes the reader around the world through the globalised pig-butchering industries – large-scale, tech-enabled financial fraud operations – in Southeast Asian countries such as Myanmar, Cambodia, and Laos, and their victims in the U.S.

The “cybers” in all three books cause tremendous damage. In one instance, they leave two members of a family dead and one aimlessly exploring Jamtara in search of answers. The books’ response to the question of motive boils down to opportunity (enabled by cheap mobile data), penury, and greed. While Chakraborty attributes some of their eventual capture to unlucky encounters with powerful victims, Poonam’s reporting suggests that successfully duping the rich and famous became a coveted status symbol.

There are enough explanations to go around for how the scam industry grew so massive – on the victims’ end, an unfamiliarity with the rapidly evolving internet; on the perpetrators’ end, entire villages left behind with little by way of social mobility; and a weak rule of law that makes it difficult to dismantle the industry and deter would-be cybercriminals.

While the books, particularly Gupta’s and Chakraborty’s, offer in-depth advice on how to avoid falling prey to scams, perhaps the best way to do so is to understand how the ecosystem came about and persists. After all, learning about fraud is in and of itself a cautionary tale.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

“Hi, come on in. Nice pair of jeans. Where did you buy them?”

“At Jeansworld. And they cost me only Rs. 150.”

“Is there a sale going on?”

“No, no sale. I exchanged my old pair of jeans with this new pair.”

“For a new pair.”

“What?”

“You don’t exchange something ‘with’ something. You usually exchange something ‘for’ something.”

“My father is planning to exchange his old scooter for a new one. How does that sound?”

“The example is an excellent one. But do you seriously think someone will pay money for that rusty old thing?”

“Well, I’m not really sure.”

“I have a feeling that your father will have to pay money to get rid of it!”

“My mother would agree with you. She’s been asking him to get rid of the old scooter for about ten years now. But he keeps telling her that he can’t. Apparently it was a gift from his father. Anyway, how about this example? The old farmer exchanged his wheat for oil.”

“Good! Now then, how about....”

“.... listen, does this mean it’s wrong to say ‘exchange with’?”

“Of course not. You can use both ‘exchange with’ and ‘exchange for’. What you have to remember is you ‘exchange something for something’ and you ‘exchange something with someone.’”

“In other words, you use ‘exchange with’ to indicate trading between people, not between things.”

“Here’s an example. The two students exchanged coats with each other.”

“Sujatha exchanges books with many of her friends. How does that sound?”

“Fine. I exchange greetings with Ajit on 1st January. That’s the only time I ring him up.”

“That’s understandable.”

“There are lots of people who want to talk to him. Many people think he’s very intelligent.”

“Those people must be crazy. You know, sometimes I think people are not really interested.... That reminds me, what is the difference between ‘some time’ and ‘sometime’?”

“Well, ‘some time’ is normally used to indicate some amount of time. The duration could be very short or long. It could be five minutes or ten years. For example, I need some time to finish writing this letter.”

“Karthick always makes it a point to spend some time with his grandparents during the summer.”

“As a child, Padma spent quite some time in Gwalior. Her Hindi is excellent.”

“In all these examples, would it be wrong to use ‘sometime’?”

“Yes, it would. ‘Sometime’ is normally used to refer to indefinite time in the future or the past. For example, ‘Pramod will be arriving sometime next month’.”

“So, what you are saying is that Pramod will be arriving next month, but you don’t know when. That is, you don’t know the date and the time.”

“That’s right. The sentence gives you a general idea as to when Pramod is arriving, but it does not specify when exactly. Would it be possible for me to come and see you sometime tomorrow?”

“The Guptas have been married for 25 years. They have been married for quite some time.”

“I hope to get married sometime next year.”

“No girl in her right mind would marry you.”

Published in The Hindu on October 9, 2001

THE DAILY QUIZ

On August 27, 410 CE, the three-day sack of Rome by the Visigoths came to an end, shocking the ancient world; how much do you know about the sack and its significance?

Prathmesh Kher

- QUESTION 1**
Who led the Visigoths who sacked Rome in 410 CE?
- QUESTION 2**
For approximately how long had Rome avoided being sacked by a foreign enemy before 410 CE?
- QUESTION 3**
Which Roman emperor was ruling the Western Roman Empire when Rome was sacked?
- QUESTION 4**
Which city served as the capital of the Eastern Roman Empire at the time?
- QUESTION 5**
Which Christian theologian wrote The City of God in the aftermath of the sack of Rome, addressing arguments that the rise of Christianity had contributed to Rome’s troubles?



Visual Question: Identify the Roman writer who described the catastrophe with the words, “The City which had taken the whole world was itself taken.” PUBLIC DOMAIN

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. In which year was it held? **Ans: 1881**

2. Out of the four, how many Grand Slam tournaments were not affected by cancellation due to World War I and World War II, nor interrupted by the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020? **Ans: U.S. Open**

3. The U.S. Open became the first Grand Slam tournament to award equal prize money to men and women, with that year’s singles champions. In which year did this happen? **Ans: 1973**

4. In 2006, the U.S. Open introduced instant replay reviews of line calls, using the Hawk-Eye computer system. It

was the first Grand Slam tournament to use the system. The Open felt the need to implement the system because of the controversial quarterfinal match at the 2004 U.S. Open between which players? **Ans: Serena Williams and Jennifer Capriati**

5. Who are the current men’s singles and women’s singles champions? **Ans: Carlos Alcaraz and Aryna Sabalenka**

Visual: Identify this U.S. Open record holder. What record has she held? **Ans: Molla Mallory; she is the record holder in women’s singles**

Early Birds: Tamal Biswas | Sukdev Shet | Tito Shiladitya | Lalchand Bhutani | Sitaram Saharaya

Word of the day

Rebarbative: serving or tending to repel

Synonyms: irritating, annoying, disturbing, aggravating

Usage: *His rebarbative manner annoyed everyone.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/rebarbative

International Phonetic Alphabet: /rɪbɑːtətv/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

India improvising on the fly as Strait of Hormuz waters remain still

NEWS ANALYSIS
M. Kalyanaraman
CHENNAI

Iran and Oman officials and ministers continue to meet to come up with a framework to administer the Strait of Hormuz so traffic can restart. The two countries seem to have buried their differences that cropped up end of June when Iran vehemently opposed an additional route hugging Oman's coast that would allow ship transit. But Washington has been unwilling to give Iran much leverage on the strait, leave alone let Iran charge a toll. So, six months after the war began, the strait remains practically closed. With little strategic stor-

age, India has been improvising on the fly, managing to keep things going. A gamechanger would be if China starts competing for Russian oil in a big way with India. Saudi Arabia and the UAE have sought land-route alternatives to Yanbu and Fujairah ports, but only for crude oil, not for petroleum products, LPG or LNG. Some 5 million barrels, roughly a third of pre-war crude flows, are still moving out of the region, though Houthi attacks have cut that by nearly 1 million barrels on some days. Some high-risk shippers still operate vessels including LNG and LPG carriers across the Strait for a premium, often slipping through at night with elec-

tronic identification switched off. Average Strait of Hormuz flows now stand at close to 0.25 million barrels a day, against 15 million before the war, estimates Pankaj Srivastava, SVP at Rystad Energy. China has so far largely sidestepped the crisis through deep strategic reserves, pipeline alternatives, and a pivot to electric vehicles and renewables. India, with minimal strategic petroleum reserves and almost no strategic gas reserves, has instead scrambled to build alternative supplies – chiefly Russian crude and U.S. LPG – while leaning on demand destruction and refinery expansion, even as it continues occasional Hormuz transits. India has walked a deli-



Chinese checkers: A gamechanger would be if China starts competing for Russian oil in a big way with India. REUTERS

“India’s strategic oil storage of 5.33 million tonnes will last just nine days, but commercial stocks at refineries can provide a cushion of a month or slightly more,” Mr. Srivastava says. India has walked a deli-

cate line: leveraging ties with Iran for ship transit, working with Oman and UAE to keep supplies flowing, and avoiding antagonising the U.S. ADNOC LNG ships have continued docking in India through the war, though the Iranian attack on Al Reykayat in early July acted as a dampener. Prashant Vasisht, SVP at ICRA, says China, until now more reliant on its own strategic reserves, has now started chasing Russian oil and competing with India for it. “What is providing some cushion for Brent is the IEA’s 400-million-barrel strategic reserve release, of which some 290 million have already been consumed,” he says, warning of the consequences of its depletion. In the war’s early days, India had some 22 Indian-flagged vessels in the Gulf, along with many ships carrying energy cargo bound for the country. As of last week, six Indian-flagged

and eight foreign-flagged vessels of Indian interest remained west of the strait, carrying 171 Indian seafarers. **Vessel movement** Some 63 India-bound cargo vessels have transited the strait since the war began, against an estimated 950-1,000 vessels that have left the strait overall, per Lloyd’s List. Of the 63, 24 were Indian-flagged and 39 foreign-flagged: 29 bulk carriers, many carrying fertilisers or fertiliser inputs, 14 LPG carriers, 12 crude carriers, two LNG carriers and so on. Eight fertiliser-carrying ships for India remain west of the strait, still awaited. India’s LPG delivery runs on a just-in-time sys-

tem built around Indian tonnage sufficient for the four-to-seven-day Gulf voyage. As India pivots to the U.S. – Kpler estimates America supplied some 60% of India’s LPG imports in May – ships have been rerouted accordingly. India lacks enough vessels to be self-reliant on the six-week U.S. route, forcing it to buy relentlessly from other carriers even while pushing domestic production 30% above pre-war levels. Longer voyages, higher prices, and freight inflation have taken their toll: LPG under-recoveries per cylinder have tripled for oil companies, with a modest price hike doing little to help. “Barmer refinery starting up is a welcome relief,” adds Mr. Srivastava.

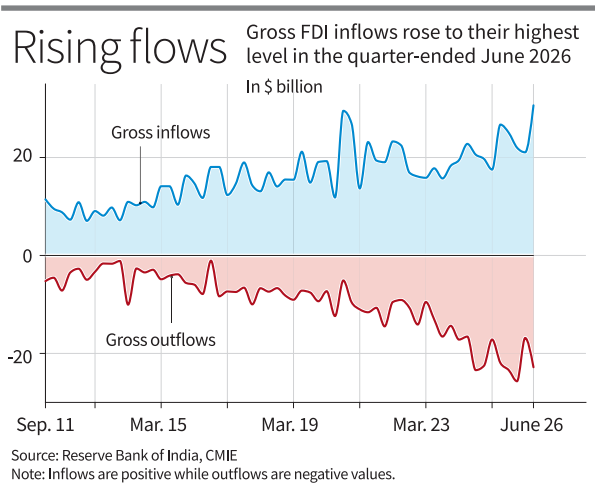
Gross FDI hit 15-year high of \$30.7 billion in April-June 2026

An analysis of latest RBI data shows net FDI turned positive again in June 2026, with inflows exceeding outflows by \$1.3 billion that month

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India attracted a total of \$30.7 billion as gross foreign direct investment in the April-June 2026 quarter, the highest level in at least 15 years. This strong inward flow overshadowed outflows, resulting in net FDI in the quarter rising to its highest level since June 2022. An analysis of the latest data released by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) shows that net FDI turned positive again in June 2026, with inflows exceeding outflows by \$1.3 billion that month, driven by an increase in investment entering the country and a fall in outward investment by Indian companies. A longer-term analysis also shows that inflows are starting to outpace outflows on a more regular basis. For instance, while net FDI was negative in six out of the last 12 months, it was negative in only one of the last six months.

Strong inflows Gross inflows in June 2026, or the total amount of direct investment that entered the country that month, stood at \$9.3 billion. This was 53% higher than in May, but just a little lower than the \$9.6 billion that entered the country in



June last year. According to the RBI, Singapore, the Netherlands, the U.S., and Canada accounted for around 74% of the inflows. The manufacturing sector received the highest share of inflows, followed by electricity generation, computer, and communication services. On a quarterly basis, gross inflows stood at \$30.7 billion in April-June 2026, which was nearly 46% higher than in the quarter ended March 2026 and about 15% higher than June 2025 quarter. This was also the highest inflow recorded in the accessible data, which goes back 60 quarters or 15 years to the September 2011 quarter. According to the RBI, this underscores the “continued interest of

global investors in India”. Total outflows of direct investment stood at \$7.9 billion in June 2026, which was nearly 30% higher than in May, and 8.6% higher than in June of last year. On a quarterly basis, total outflows stood at \$22.8 billion. As a result, net FDI stood at \$1.3 billion in June 2026 and \$7.8 billion in the April-June 2026 quarter. Within outflows, repatriation and disinvestment by foreign companies operating in India grew to \$5.8 billion in June 2026, 57% higher than in May, and 36% higher than in June last year. Outward FDI by Indian firms, on the other hand, fell to \$2.1 billion during this period, down 13% over May 2026 and 30% lower than in June 2025.

JSW Group in talks with SAIC of China to increase stake in JV

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

The Sajjan Jindal-led JSW Group is in talks with China’s SAIC Motor to increase its stake in their joint venture, JSW MG Motor India, as the group looks to expand its presence in the Indian automobile sector. “We are talking to them, so it’s between shareholders right now. Again, I won’t comment on how much because it’s all under discussion at this stage,” JSW MG Motor India Director Parth Jindal told journalists in Mumbai on Wednesday. According to reports, JSW Group is seeking to increase its stake in the joint venture by about 10%. JSW currently holds 35%, while SAIC Motor owns 49%. The remaining stake is held by Indian institutional investors, employees of JSW MG Motor India and the company’s dealers. Apart from JSW MG Motor India, the group is setting up a separate automobile company, JSW Motor Ltd., which will focus on manufacturing electric vehicles. JSW Group is also in discussions with Skoda Auto Volkswagen India for a potential acquisition of a majority stake. If the proposed transactions materialise, JSW Group would emerge as a significant player in India’s automotive industry, with investments across three entities and a portfolio spanning multiple brands.

Retail sugar prices stabilise, likely to see drop in coming days

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

Retail sugar prices in most of the markets across the country continued to hover between ₹65 and ₹70 a kg with a section of traders expecting the prices to drop in the coming days. In Uttar Pradesh, which is one of the main sugar producing States, retail sugar prices ranged between ₹50 and ₹65 per kg in the midst of fears in the market of shortage. “The price has risen by over ₹10 in the last 15 days,” said Vikas Gautam, a customer based in Lucknow. In Mumbai, the prices were ₹77-80 a kg. However, bulk buyers said they had adequate stocks. In Hyderabad, some of the outlets have restricted the quantity that can be purchased. In Coimbatore, Tamil Nadu, the retail price is ₹69-70 a kg, while restaurant and sweet and savoury outlets were getting sugar from wholesale dealers at ₹67-70 a kg. “We have a six-month contract with our supplier. He is asking for a revision of the contract now as the prices are increasing,” said



In Uttar Pradesh, retail sugar prices ranged between ₹50 and ₹65 per kg.

one of the large-scale restaurant owners in Coimbatore. According to C. Dorairaj, president of the Indian Chamber of Commerce and Industry, Coimbatore, retail prices have stabilised in the last couple of days and some of the wholesale markets have seen a slight drop in prices too. The Uttar Pradesh government has intensified action against hoarding and said there is no shortage in availability of sugar. According to Vishal Nirani, MD of Nirani Sugars, Karnataka expected sugar production of 6.5 million tonnes in the current season. Due to erratic climatic conditions, the actual production is 5.7 MT.

INBRIEF



ICAT issues first compliance certificate for multi-axle bus

The International Centre for Automotive Technology (ICAT) has issued its first compliance certificate for a 15-metre multi-axle sleeper bus, marking a significant step in the certification of longer and more complex passenger vehicles for India’s inter-city transport sector. The certificate has been awarded to Synaty Automotive Pvt. Ltd.’s bus, certified under AIS-119 and AIS-153 in accordance with the applicable provisions of the Central Motor Vehicles Rules. The certification comes amid heightened scrutiny of sleeper bus safety following series of fatal fires and accidents.

JSW Group puts battery plant on hold over tech constraints

The JSW Group has put its proposed battery manufacturing plant in Odisha on hold as it continues to look for a technology partner for lithium iron phosphate (LFP) battery cells, Parth Jindal, Director of JSW MG Motor India and Managing Director of JSW Cement and JSW Paints, said on Wednesday. “We are very keen to make cells in India. But the LFP technology currently is not available for us. The hunt is on for a technology tie-up. We have not yet secured a technology tie-up, and hence, that project currently is on hold,” Mr. Jindal said in Mumbai.

Gradiant expects India business to double next year as PCB demand rises

Balasubramanyam C.P.
COIMBATORE

Industrial water technology company Gradiant expects its India business to double next year, driven by growing demand from semiconductor, solar, printed circuit board (PCB) and data centre projects, even as it faces challenges in building the engineering and execution capacity needed to deliver its expanding order book. “It is not about getting more orders. It is how do I convert that order and execute them and create that capacity and capability,” Gradiant COO Govind Alagappan said at a media interaction in Coimbatore. The Woburn-based company currently generates revenue in the range of \$500 million-\$750 million, with India accounting for about 10%. Gradiant expects \$1 billion in global revenue over the next two to three years. While it did not disclose its current India revenue, the company said the business is expected to double next year. Its global order book is approaching \$1 billion, according to the company. Equipment deliveries typi-

Semiconductors are currently Gradiant’s biggest focus in India, alongside PCB manufacturing

cally take nine to 12 months, while projects in faster-moving segments such as solar and data centres can take less than 18 months from initial discussions to handover. Gradiant designs, builds and operates systems for treating, recycling and recovering water and wastewater used by industrial customers. Its client base spans semiconductors, solar, data centres, pharmaceuticals, food and beverage and other industries. The company was founded in 2013 by MIT researchers Anurag Bajpayee and Prakash Govindan. Semiconductors are currently Gradiant’s biggest focus in India, alongside PCB manufacturing and the solar photovoltaic manufacturing ecosystem. The company said it is involved in two of the largest semiconductor water-treatment deployments in India, although it did not disclose the customers.

One of the projects is already entering the start-up phase. Gradiant’s semiconductor solutions cover both the production of ultrapure water required in chip manufacturing and the treatment of wastewater generated during the manufacturing process. Gradiant said it has more than 50% market share in the solar segment, based on its presence among major solar manufacturers using its technologies for ultrapure water and water recycling. Its India business covers solar-cell manufacturing as well as ingot and wafer production. **Data centres** Data centres are another emerging opportunity, although the company said large-scale investments in the sector have yet to fully materialise in India. “We’ve gotten into the top four hyperscalers in Europe, in the US, and in Southeast Asia. We are in early stage discussions in India,” the company said. According to the company, water availability is becoming a critical constraint for large data centres, particularly as cooling require-

ments rise with the scale of new facilities. Gradiant said newer hyperscale and AI data centres can range from 500 MW to 1 GW, making them substantially larger than facilities being built two years ago. Geopolitical tensions have affected Gradiant’s West Asia operations, with the company estimating an impact of about 20% on revenue growth in the region. In India, however, it said it currently sees no major policy or supply-chain constraints. Gradiant has around 250 employees in India across its Chennai and Coimbatore operations. The two locations form its Global Engineering Centre (GEC), which supports projects worldwide. The GEC is responsible for detailed engineering work across Gradiant’s global projects, including process design and manufacturing drawings. The company said the Chennai-Coimbatore engineering operation is pivotal to almost three quarters of its revenue. (The writer was in Coimbatore at the invitation of the company)

Luxury apparel store Pernia to raise ₹680 cr. through IPO

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Luxury fashion platform Pernia’s Pop-Up Studio’s parent company, Purple Style Labs (PSL), is set to raise as much as ₹680 crore through its initial public offering (IPO), providing PSL with additional capital to expand its physical retail footprint, while supporting its broader omnichannel growth strategy. The company has fixed the IPO price band at ₹546-575 per equity share. The minimum lot size is 26 shares, with investors required to bid in multiples of 26 shares thereof. Around ₹371 crore from the initial public offer proceeds would be invested in PSL’s wholly owned subsidiary, PSL Retail.

Bajaj General Insurance unveils health insurance plan for families with pets

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Bajaj General Insurance has launched ‘My Family Complete’, a health insurance plan that expands the definition of family to include pet dogs and cats. The plan aims to address fragmented health protection by bringing human family members and pets under a single insurance policy. It offers sum insured options ranging from ₹5 lakh to ₹5 crore, with policy tenures of up to five years and a combination of indemnity- and benefit-based payouts. Dogs and cats aged three months and above are eligible, with no upper age limit.



Bajaj expands health cover to include pets (For illustration) REUTERS

Bajaj General Insurance MD and CEO Tapan Singhel said insurance needs to evolve with changing lifestyles and family structures. “When pets are family, their health and wellbeing naturally become a part of the family’s healthcare

needs. We are responding to this need by bringing pets into the family health insurance fold,” he added. The policy covers in-patient hospitalisation, room rent, road and pet ambulance services, pre- and post-hospitalisation expenses, domiciliary care, modern treatment methods, AYUSH hospitalisation (for humans), organ donor expenses and family visit reimbursements. For pets, the plan includes benefits such as reimbursement for advertising and rewards when a pet goes missing, emergency pet accommodation if the pet parent is hospitalised, and third-party liability coverage for injury, death or property damage caused by the insured pet.

China exports help ease pain for London zinc shorts



China has started lifting exports, dispatching metal straight to LME warehouses in Hong Kong. REUTERS

Reuters

The London zinc market remains a dangerous place for bears. The metal that everyone thought would go down in price this year is marching ever higher. London Metal Exchange (LME) three-month zinc hit a fresh four-year peak of \$3,858 per metric tonne on Tuesday morning. More worryingly for zinc short-position holders, the relentless rally is being accompanied by a sharp contraction in LME time-spreads. The premium for cash metal over three-month delivery <CMZNO-3> has flexed out to \$131 per tonne, a flashback to last October when it hit a record-breaking high of \$323 per tonne. Low LME inventory was the trigger for last year's squeeze and is the reason the market is tightening again. The good news for LME shorts is that help may be on its way. China has started lifting exports, dispatching metal straight to LME warehouses in Hong Kong.

A tale of two markets

It's not as if zinc demand has been booming. The International Lead and Zinc Study Group (ILZSG) estimates global usage grew by a modest 1.5% year-on-year from January to May. Refined metal output grew faster, at 3.5%, leading the Group to assess a global supply surplus of around 1,45,000 tonnes in the first five months of the year. The catch, however, is that most of the refined production growth came from China, as was the case last year. Western smelters have suffered a string of supply hits and are under extreme margin pressure due to the collapse in treatment terms. Most of the surplus metal, therefore, is also in China. Stocks registered with the Shanghai Futures Exchange have more than doubled to 1,55,954 tonnes since the start of January. LME stocks, including those sitting in off-warrant storage, are still 6,500 tons lower at 124,677 tonnes despite the recent daily deliveries into LME warehouses.

Hong Kong fast-track

There has been daily warranting action since the start of last week as the rising LME premium for cash delivery draws metal into the system. Volumes have totalled a modest 17,000 tonnes so far, but they've been enough to stabilise on-warrant inventory around the 95,000-tonne level. There has also been a build in off-warrant stocks, which have risen from a July low of 15,480 tonnes to 29,627 tonnes. Hong Kong has accounted for around two-thirds of the deliveries onto LME warrant and holds another 5,000 tonnes in off-warrant storage. The LME approved the city for good delivery in January last year, and the first warehouse only opened for business in July, but Hong Kong is clearly already acting as a fast-speed conduit for physical arbitrage. China has historically been a big importer of refined zinc. Volumes were as high as 4,45,000 tonnes as recently as 2024. But domestic smelter capacity has grown to the point that the country is approaching self-sufficiency. Imports fell by a third to 2,99,000 tonnes last year and China turned net exporter in both November and December, delivering metal to LME warehouses in Singapore and Taiwan to profit from the cash squeeze on the London market. It turned net exporter again in July to the tune of 4,100 tonnes as outbound volumes rose to 9,200 tonnes and imports continued to tumble, according to local data provider Shanghai Metal Market (SMM). The pace of arrivals is clearly slower this time around. So far.

Turning bullish

Bulls are betting that even China's smelters will have to rein back operating rates as bombed-out treatment charges compress margins. Investment funds have accumulated over 110,000 tonnes of long positions, by some margin the largest collective bet on higher prices since the LME started publishing its positioning reports in 2018. Rekindled enthusiasm for zinc is also evident in the LME options market. There are almost 1,500 lots of open interest on December calls at a strike price of \$4,000 per tonne and another 757 lots at the \$4,500-per-tonne strike. The bull narrative is one of restricted mine supply. After three consecutive years of decline, global mine production jumped by 4.8% last year. However, the impetus has quickly faded this year, with annual growth slowing to just 1.1% from January to May, according to ILZSG. The competition for mined concentrates has been so fierce that spot treatment charges for Chinese imports are now sitting at a record low of minus \$117.50 per tonne, according to SMM.

SEBI's ITRI: Global test for India's future-ready financial architecture

The need for ITRI comes at a time when India's securities market is experiencing sea changes in digital transformation as seen from increased participation of retail investors through online platforms, higher algorithmic trading volumes, and faster settlement cycles

NEWS ANALYSIS

Santosh V. Perumal
CHENNAI

Market regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has introduced a technology health scorecard for market infrastructure institutions (MIIs), to measure the robustness of their critical IT systems rather than checking the routine compliance. The SEBI's IT Resilience Index (ITRI) seems to be among the first attempts globally by a regulator to design a quantitative resilience barometer (as measurable as capital adequacy for banks) for MIIs like stock exchanges, clearing corporations and depositories. The move to assess MIIs' vulnerabilities comes in view of the rising technological dependence of Indian capital markets, where even a few minutes of disruption can affect millions of investors and billions of rupees in trades. The ITRI will gauge whether the IT systems supporting trading, clearing, settlement and securities holding are capable of handling operational shocks, cyber threats, technical failures and sudden spikes in market activity. The foundation for the proposed index was laid in 2015, when SEBI, through a circular, termed MIIs "systemically important", thus calling for a "robust" cybersecurity framework to perform systemically critical functions. The need for ITRI comes at a time when India's securities market is experiencing sea changes in digital transformation as seen from increased parti-



Watch tower: The ITRI will gauge whether the IT systems supporting trading, clearing, and securities holding are capable of handling operational shocks and sudden spikes in market activity. REUTERS

cipation of retail investors through online platforms, higher algorithmic trading volumes, and faster settlement cycles. Market efficiency has now become inseparable from technology reliability, becoming a boardroom issue.

Risk prioritisation

The proposed index -- which seeks to shift from a pure compliance-based mode to a quantitative risk-monitoring framework -- will be based on nine parameters, each weighted on the basis of a systemic risk hierarchy, even as questions remain on the statistical estimation of the proposed weights, which have been assigned after discussions with its Technical Advisory Committee. The Industry Standards Forum of MIIs would further define the detailed sub-parameters and measurement criteria. The weighting exercise implies risk-prioritisation approach, which is giving greater importance to parameters whose failure can immediately disrupt the functioning of MIIs. The availability and security have been accorded



The foundation for the proposed index was laid in 2015, when SEBI termed MIIs systemically important, calling for a robust cybersecurity framework

the highest weight (20% each) as they represent the first line of defence for a financial market's functioning.

The 10% weightage on Business Continuity and Reliability rather reflects a change in regulatory perspective. Focus was earlier on preventing failures, but over time, resilience frameworks focus on absorbing shocks and recovering quickly. Scalability has been assigned 5% weight amid SEBI's view that Indian markets are growing rapidly but not an immediate stability risk. The present weights should at the best be seen as a starting framework because the market regulator may have to refine them using actual outage data,

cyber incidents and stress tests. MIIs would also develop an Early Warning System (EWS) to detect any deterioration in ITRI parameters that could potentially lead to performance issues, system slowness or other disruptions, and take remedial measures.

Global experiences

Several markets have created similar operational resilience frameworks, though not always in the form of a single ITRI. The U.K.'s Financial Conduct Authority and Prudential Regulation Authority had put in place operational resilience rules requiring financial institutions to identify important business services, set disruption tolerances and demonstrate their ability to recover from severe operational shocks. Unlike SEBI's proposed index, the European Union's most comprehensive Digital Operational Resilience Act (DORA) is a regulatory rulebook rather than a numerical scorecard. The U.S. does not have a single ITRI for bourses, in-

stead, technology resilience is embedded into regulatory oversight. Singapore's Monetary Authority of Singapore has one of Asia's strongest technology risk guidelines, which could be particularly relevant for India since both countries have highly digital financial ecosystems and large retail presence. Hong Kong's regulators have developed cyber resilience assessment frameworks for financial institutions and market intermediaries, closer to SEBI's strategy as it uses measurable maturity levels and regulators rely on comprehensive operational resilience frameworks and cross-sectoral exercises than a numeric scoring index. Australia follows a resilience-based approach through regulators such as Australian Securities and Investments Commission and Australian Prudential Regulation Authority but focus areas are critical operations mapping, technology dependencies, outsourcing risks, and cyber recovery.

How ITRI is different? Most regulators worldwide follow a principle-based operational resilience model but SEBI's distinctive model attempts to convert resilience into a measurable index.

With India's capital markets becoming among the most technology-intensive globally, a failure at an exchange or clearing corporation level is not just an IT problem; but a financial stability risk. The EWS identifies weaknesses before they become failures. With increasing dependence on AI (artificial intelligence), cloud infrastructure, high-frequency trading and digital settle-

Litmus test SEBI's ITRI is a global assessment of India's ability to build a future-ready financial market architecture. The real test will be whether a high score translates into faster recovery in the event of an actual cyberattack, system outage or technology shocks. If implemented effectively, it could become a global template to safeguard the digital foundations of finance.

U.S.-Iran war sinks into energy trench warfare

Reuters
LONDON

Six months into the U.S.-Iran war, the conflict is hardening into a stalemate that could last well into 2027, with energy markets held hostage, inflation elevated and neither side willing - or able - to back down. The war, which has killed thousands and inflicted extensive damage across the Middle East, has undergone a profound transformation. It began on February 28 as a joint U.S.-Israeli effort to cripple Iran militarily, aiming to eliminate Tehran's nuclear programme, weaken its proxy network and potentially topple the government. But it has evolved into a narrower struggle focused on one question: who controls the Strait of Hormuz, the narrow waterway used to carry roughly a fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas supplies. Duelling Iranian and U.S. blockades have sharply curtailed traffic through the strait over the past six months, disrupting energy markets and imposing mounting costs on global economies. While crude prices have not spiked as anticipated - largely thanks to ample global inventories, reduced Chinese imports and increased oil production outside the Gulf - Brent crude remains around \$90 per barrel,

roughly 25% above its pre-war level. Market buffers that cushioned the initial energy shock are now largely exhausted - a worrying sign. This risk might be expected to spur the Trump administration to resolve the crisis by either doubling down or retreating entirely. Yet the intractability of the stalemate remains striking. Neither side has demonstrated a willingness - or a convincing strategy - to break the deadlock.

No way out

Iran appears unlikely to blink first. Its economy has suffered enormously. U.S. efforts to choke off oil exports - Tehran's main source of revenue - have cut them by about 85% from pre-war levels, to 2,50,000 barrels per day (bpd) in August, fuelling inflation and deepening hardship. Yet the government has proven far more resilient than anticipated. Rather than collapsing after Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei was killed in an Israeli air strike on the war's first day, the Iranian government has adapted and hardened its position. Iran may be unable to dominate the region militarily, but it has demonstrated an ability to inflict economic pain on its adversaries through effective control of Hormuz, using periodic attacks and



After shocks: Even if additional crude begins flowing through Hormuz, rebuilding refining capacity will take far longer. REUTERS

threats against tankers. Meanwhile, U.S. President Donald Trump has indicated little interest in escalating the conflict in ways that could truly endanger U.S. troops or the global economy. With November's U.S. midterm elections approaching, the conflict has become increasingly unpopular with U.S. voters as energy-driven inflation has amplified cost-of-living concerns. This leaves Washington with one key objective: restoring energy flows through Hormuz and lowering fuel prices at home. The question is how?

Beyond Hormuz

The conflict has exposed the real bottleneck in the global energy system. It's not crude supply but refining capacity. Around a fifth of Middle Eastern refining capacity is offline because of war damage or export disruptions. Chinese refin-

ery activity is running well below year-ago levels, and Russian refinery throughput remains constrained by Ukrainian drone attacks. Combined, these disruptions reduced global refinery runs in August by roughly 4 million bpd, or 5%, from a year earlier, according to Energy Aspects. The result is a growing shortage of fuels. That distinction matters politically for the Trump administration because voters buy gasoline, not crude oil. U.S. gasoline prices have risen roughly 30% over the past year, while diesel prices have surged more than 50%. Even if additional crude begins flowing through Hormuz, rebuilding refining capacity will take far longer. The administration's options for bringing down domestic fuel prices are narrowing by the day. Recent White House moves underscore these

limitations. On Monday, U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent expanded sanctions against Tehran and threatened secondary measures against countries continuing to do business with it, describing the campaign as an "economic D-Day." Yet sanctions are unlikely to deliver breakthroughs, and threats of secondary sanctions hold little weight when Bessent has made clear that Washington seeks to avoid actions that could seriously upset the global economy. That reduces the likelihood that the U.S. will impose severe penalties on China, Tehran's largest oil customer - one of the few economic measures that could move the needle with Iran. Washington is also attempting to jawbone markets by arguing that oil flows through Hormuz are recovering rapidly despite Iranian threats. Over the past week, senior White House officials have argued that Gulf exports are approaching pre-war levels as more tankers depart under U.S. naval protection, with their transponders turned off. Energy Secretary Chris Wright said on Friday that the seven-day average for oil leaving Hormuz had climbed above 8 million bpd. However, shipping analytics firms monitoring Hormuz through satellite imagery and vessel-tracking data see little evidence of a recovery. Oil exports through the strait have averaged just 2.2million bpd so far in August, according to Kpler. Total regional crude exports, including shipments from Saudi and Emirati ports that bypass Hormuz, averaged about 9 million bpd this month, down from 11 million bpd in July and roughly 17 million bpd in 2025. While the administration may be seeking a deal behind the scenes, the contrast between Washington's public claims and the data suggests desperation rather than strength. The longer the conflict drags on, the harder it becomes for Trump to argue it is succeeding. The Islamic government remains in power, Hormuz remains constrained, fuel prices remain elevated and economic costs continue to mount. The U.S. possesses overwhelming economic and military power but little appetite for a wider war. Iran is economically weakened, yet has demonstrated a willingness to absorb extraordinary pain to pursue strategic goals. The conflict is a contest of endurance rather than manoeuvre. Despite what Trump and Bessent argued this week, U.S. economic pressure resembles the grinding trench warfare that kept World War One going far more than the decisive Allied offensives that ended World War Two.

INBRIEF



Chotrani, Senthilkumar in Budapest squash quarters

Veer Chotrani, in pic, and Velavan Senthilkumar advanced to the quarterfinals of the Budapest Open, a \$43,500 PSA copper event. Chotrani, the third seed, beat Rui Soares of Portugal 13-11, 12-14, 11-9, 12-10 in the pre-quarterfinals following a first-round bye in the new season. Senthilkumar, the eighth seed, defeated German fifth seed Raphael Kandra 11-9, 6-11, 11-7, 11-2 in the pre-quarterfinals after putting it past Briton Will Salter 11-9, 11-6, 11-5 in the opening round.



Andrews named asst. coach of U-17 women's football team

The All India Football Federation has appointed Anthony Andrews as the U17 women's national team's assistant coach under head coach Joakim Alexandersson. Andrews, who also serves as head coach of East Bengal FC, will take up the role on a dual basis with the club and country.

India names squad for AFC U-20 Asian Cup Qualifiers

India on Wednesday named a 23-member squad for the upcoming AFC U-20 Asian Cup Qualifiers in Tashkent. The qualifying tournament will be held in the Uzbek capital from August 31 to September 6 and the main tournament will be held in China next year. The Blue Colts will face Syria on Aug. 31, host Uzbekistan on Sept. 3 and Bangladesh on Sept. 6. The group winners and the seven best runners-up across all eight groups will qualify for AFC U-20 Asian Cup China 2027.

The squad: Goalkeepers: Jaskaran Dub, Pranav Sundarraman, Suraj Singh Aheibam; **Defenders:** Asher Rebello, Bungson Singh Takhellambam, Karish Soram, Malemngamba Singh Thokchom, Sumit Sharma Brahmacharimayum, Yaipharemba Chingakhom. **Midfielders:** Aniket Yadav, Danny Meitei Laishram, Md. Arbash, Rishi Singh Ningthoukhongjam, Rishikanta Meitei Laishram, Samson Ahongshangbam, Shami Singamayum; **Forwards:** Daniyal Makakmayum, Gunleiba Wangkheirakpam, Hateem Ali, Omang Dodum, Prashan Jajo, Rohen Singh Chaphamayum, Vishal Yadav.



Teenager Bouaddi joins Man City for record £85.6m

Morocco midfielder Ayyoub Bouaddi has become the most expensive teenager in Premier League history after joining Manchester City from Lille in a five-year deal the French club said Wednesday was worth £85.6 million. The fee surpasses Manchester United's £58.9 million deal for Leny Yoro, also signed from Lille, in 2024.



Fernandes and Shaw voted PFA players of the year

Bruno Fernandes was voted the men's player of the year in English football for last season at the Professional Footballers' Association awards on Tuesday. Khadija "Bunny" Shaw got the women's accolade. The Manchester United captain and Manchester City forward their wins from May in votes by members of the Football Writers' Association. The PFA winners are were selected for the honour by their fellow players.



Sweating it out: Babar had a long batting session at the nets ahead of his impending return. AP

England eyes series sweep, Babar returns for Pakistan

The hosts would hope to bring their A-game and keep the white noise away; the visitors seek all-round improvement after Headingley horror

CRICKET

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

England will aim to put its latest drinking drama behind it when it faces Pakistan in the second Test at Lord's starting on Thursday.

Root spent much of a pre-match press conference talking about Brydon Carse, dropped from the squad and now under investigation by the Cricket Regulator after videos on social media showed the fast bowler being led away by police in handcuffs following an incident at a Derby nightclub on Saturday.

England, with seamers

Ollie Robinson and Josh Tongue taking eight wickets apiece, skittled out Pakistan for just 171 and 135 in the first Test while posting 409 itself, even though none of its four batsmen who reached fifty, a quartet including Root, went on to a century.

All-round deficiency
By contrast, Pakistan was deficient in all departments with its inadequate batting compounded by an inaccurate and largely unthreatening pace attack.

Pakistan captain Babar Azam has said he is "90 per cent fit" as he returns to lead his country in the second Test against England.

"I've had a couple of

practice sessions again and I'm 90% fit for the match tomorrow. Always when you lead Pakistan, especially at this ground, it is an honour for me and I will do my best," he said.

The teams: (from):
England: Joe Root (Capt.), Harry Brook, Jordan Cox, Ben Duckett, Emilio Gay, Dan Lawrence, Ollie Pope, Jamie Smith (wk), Jofra Archer, Gus Atkinson, Sonny Baker, Sam Cook, Matthew Fisher, Ollie Robinson, Shoaib Bashir and Josh Tongue.

Pakistan: Babar Azam (Capt.), Abdullah Shafique, Awais Zafar, Azan Awais, Ghazi Ghori (wk), Imam-ul-Haq, Mohammad Rizwan (wk), Saud Shakeel, Shan Masood, Salman Agha, Aamer Jamal, Ali Usman, Khurram Shahzad, Mohammad Abbas, Mohammad Ali, Sajid Khan and Ubaid Shah.

We keep making stupid mistakes away from the game: Root

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Joe Root expressed his frustration that a winning return as England Test captain has been overshadowed by another off-field incident that saw Brydon Carse dropped for the second Test against Pakistan.

Carse has been referred to the Cricket Regulator after videos on social media appeared to show the fast bowler being led away by police in handcuffs following an incident at a nightclub in Derby on Saturday.

It is the latest in a series of alcohol-fuelled controversies that have dogged England since a disastrous tour of New Zealand and Australia at the end of last year.

Honest

"If I'm being brutally honest, I'm really hacked off. I'm really disappointed that, after last week's performance, we're sat here and we're talking about something that is not related to it at all," Root told a

press conference on Tuesday.

"It's not the isolated incident itself, it's the fact we continuously keep making stupid mistakes away from the game and it's detracting from what we are doing on the field."

"I still don't believe that's the way to go. It's important we create something bigger than that, it's about having something long lasting that we can be proud of," he added.

"Clearly we are not portraying ourselves how we want to and I think we have an opportunity to build a culture that is very strong, that we can be proud of, that is player driven and of course that isn't going to happen overnight.

"We have already had conversations as a team on what is expected from this group of players, what it means to play for England, what it takes to play for England.

"We want to create something that we can be proud of, that people who follow us can be proud of."



Frustrated: Root is at a loss for words while trying to fathom recent off-field incidents. GETTY IMAGES

India has the wherewithal to come up trumps in women's T20 Asia Cup: Raman

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

As India looks to regain the women's T20 Asia Cup, former head coach W.V. Raman backed the Harmanpreet Kaur-led side to triumph in the continental event that starts in the UAE on Friday.

India had a disappointing campaign in the ICC T20 World Cup earlier this year, crashing out in the group stage.

"I think that will spur them on to try and regain the Asia Cup because they are smarting from a performance that was unexpected given the squad and the expectations that everybody



Raman. FILE PHOTO

dy had," said Raman.

"I think this is a tournament that they will win because they have the wherewithal.

"This will also be a chance for them to start preparations for the next

T20 World Cup."

On the squad, the former India opener reckoned that the batting looks slightly weak compared to the World Cup squad in the absence of Jemimah Rodrigues.

"Maybe they could have thought of bringing in a couple of new medium-pacers, but that hasn't happened.

"They've gone in heavily with spinners. You have Bharti Fulmali coming back, and she's yet to prove her credentials, even though she's got the reputation of being a big hitter of a cricket ball," he added.

While India won the ODI World Cup last year,

the team has been inconsistent in T20Is, and the 61-year-old felt that it hasn't clicked as a unit.

"I have felt that Deepti Sharma has to deliver more as a batter because she's got the ability. She does that in other leagues across the world.

"Also, maybe Harmanpreet can bat at No. 3. If she can get more time, it will help her pace her innings better. It's just a question of them succeeding as a unit. I think that's what has not, perhaps, happened," said Raman.

(Watch Women's Asia Cup 2026 live on Sony Sports Ten 1 SD & HD and Sony LIV).

Total Chess World Championship Tour muscles its way into the calendar

P.K. Ajith Kumar

The chess calendar is crowded. Top players rarely get to take a breather these days with so many big events, across formats, taking place across the globe. And it is going to get even more crowded with the newly launched Total Chess World Championship Tour.

Its pilot will be held at Budapest from November 10 to 21. Lined up for the event are many of the biggest names in chess, headlined by World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen.

There are three Indians in the fray – Arjun Erigaisi and the Chennai siblings R. Praggnanandhaa and R. Vaishali. Arjun is one of the eight players from the



Ready for it: Pragg and Arjun will headline the Indian challenge in the newly launched tournament. FILE PHOTO

top-10 who will compete in Budapest.

The presence of men like Fabiano Caruana (World No. 2), Vincent Keymer (No. 5) and Wesley So (No. 6) ensures it would be a stiffly contested event, which will feature 24 players in all.

The first full tour will begin next year with four legs to be played in cities across the world. Conceived by Norway Chess, with blessings of the world governing body FIDE, the new tour combines different formats – classical, rapid and blitz. There are, of course,

separate World championships for all those categories, and the classical format Total World Chess Championship is not quite classical in fact: the time control is 45 minutes with an increment of 30 seconds per move.

That may look more rapid than classical, for which the time control is usually 90 minutes for the first 40 moves and then 30 minutes for the rest of the game with increment.

Total Chess, to be fair, isn't calling its format classical, but fast classical. That makes sense. For, classical chess needs to retain its prime place. The Total Chess Championship Tour, though, is a welcome addition. The more the merrier.

India will win gold at Asian Games: Neha



Big lessons: Sunelita believes the World Cup experience will stand her in good stead. AFP

HOCKEY

Aashin Prasad
AMSTELVEEN

Sunelita Toppo had a sleepless night after India narrowly crashed out of the World Cup. A goalless draw against Australia in Pool E of the second round pushed India to the third spot and its semifinal dream came crashing.

"We came so close and worked so hard to come here, but we couldn't achieve it. I know we finished the match in a draw, but our thinking was that we have to reach the semi-finals," Sunelita, one of the youngest members of the team, playing her maiden World Cup, told the *Hindu*.

For senior midfielder Neha, participating in her third World Cup, the result brought back painful memories of previous setbacks – loss in the bronze medal game at 2020 Olympics and defeat to Australia in the 2022 Commonwealth Games semifinal.

"The same thing happened here... everyone was very sad, crying and concerned that we had come so close and missed an [opportunity to fight for a] medal. It's very difficult,



Syndrela. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Syndrela and Payas in TOPS Development Scheme

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Asian Games-bound young table tennis players Syndrela Das and Payas Jain have been included in the Sports Ministry's Target Olympic Podium Scheme's (TOPS) Development group, while Manika Batra's request for funding to participate in international events next month has also been approved.

The 17-year-old Syndrela bagged a silver in girls' doubles and a bronze in singles at the Asian Youth Championships in Thailand earlier this year. Syndrela also won three national-ranking age-group titles (U-15, -17 and -19 singles) in 2023.

Manika will receive funding from MOC for taking part in the WTT Contender tournaments in Bulgaria and Kazakhstan, scheduled for September.

India's 10-member Asian Games squad includes Syndrela, Sreeja Akula, Diya Chitale, Yashaswini Ghorpade, Sutirtha Mukherjee, G. Sathiyam, Manush Shah, Manav Thakkar, Harmeet Desai and Payas.

